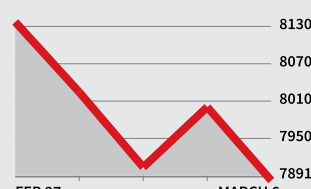


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 78918.90 (-1097.00)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	24450.45	-315.45
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	21.67	-0.30
US Dollar (in ₹)	91.74	+0.14
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	158115.00	-1828
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	260723.00	-3489

EXPORT BOOST.

Govt considering certification labs for natural farming produce to spur exports, reach global markets, says PM Modi **p8**



AUTO FOCUS.

Toyota Fortuner Neo Drive 4x4 AT adds mild-hybrid torque assist, keeps rugged charm and comfort **p4**

BENGALURU • CHENNAI • COIMBATORE • HUBBALLI • HYDERABAD • KOCHI • KOLKATA • MADURAI • MALAPPURAM • MANGALURU • MUMBAI • NOIDA • THIRUVANANTHAPURAM • TIRUCHIRAPALLI • VIJAYAWADA • VISAKHAPATNAM

Regd. TN/ARD/14/2012-2014, RNI No. 55320/94

QUICKLY.

PRICE SHOCK

At \$565 million, gold ETF inflows plunge 77% in Feb



Mumbai: Inflows into gold exchange-traded funds plunged 77 per cent last month to \$565 million down from a record high \$2.5 billion logged in January, as the sudden sharp fall in gold prices rattled investor sentiment. Gold prices have been rallying over the last few months on the back of geopolitical developments and peaked after the US imposed high trade tariffs, rattling the world. **p5**

FISCAL PLAN

Karnataka Budget pegs spending at ₹4.49 lakh cr

Bengaluru: Karnataka CM Siddaramaiah on Friday presented the State Budget for 2026-27, with an outlay of ₹4.49 lakh crore, about 10 per cent higher than the previous year. The State government has attempted to strike a balance between the welfare commitments and large-scale infrastructure investments. **p9**

Karnataka, AP propose to ban social media use by children

AGE LIMITS. Karnataka curb to cover under-16s; in Andhra Pradesh off-limit for under-13s

Our Bureaus

Bengaluru/Mumbai/Hyderabad

Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh propose to ban use of social media by children.

Karnataka becomes the first State to move towards restricting social media use for children under 16 as part of its 2026-27 Budget. Chief Minister Siddaramaiah announced the proposal while presenting his 17th Budget on Friday, citing concerns over the growing impact of mobile phone use.

AP Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu announced in the Assembly that the State government will implement a ban on social media for children below 13 years over three months.

MANY IMPACTS

The Karnataka proposal, outlined under the 'School Education' section of the Budget, aims to address issues such as excessive screen time, mental health concerns and the possible impact of digital distraction on academic performance.

According to a senior State government official who did not want to be named, the Budget expresses intent, and



WELL-BEING DRIVE. The proposal aims to address issues such as excessive screen time, mental health concerns and the possible impact of digital distraction on academic performance

the government will constitute a board to ensure its effective implementation. "At the end of the day, any ban could only be strictly enforced by parents rather than the government or the companies themselves," he added.

POLICY LIMITS

However, policy researchers say the risks associated with children's online behaviour are more complex than a single category of platforms. Questions like children migrating to Karnataka or travelling across State borders expose the territorial limits of this idea very quickly, Garima Saxena, Programme Manager, The Dia-

logue, a Delhi-based think tank, told *businessline*.

If the restriction is enforced on a geolocation basis, a child's access status would then shift with physical location. Even residence-based or account-based models would face difficulties like migration, temporary stays, inter-State students, and other mixed jurisdiction situations.

"The guardrails would have to be substantial. At a minimum, any framework would need clarity on which services are covered, what data can and cannot be collected, who bears responsibility for compliance, etc.," said Saxena.

Legal experts also flagged

potential challenges in implementing such a restriction at the State level. Aparajita Bharti, Co-founder of policy consultancy The Quantum Hub, said internet governance largely falls under Central legislation, which could make a State-specific ban difficult to enforce. Responding to the development, Meta said it would comply with social media bans where legally implemented but cautioned against policies that may push teenagers towards less regulated corners of the internet.

"Governments considering bans should be careful not to push teens toward less safe, unregulated sites, or logged out experiences that bypass important protections," the company said.

Karnataka has joined the global debate around concerns of social media usage among children and teens.

AP's PROPOSAL

Speaking in the State Assembly in Amaravati on Friday, AP CM Naidu said discussions were underway with experts on the modalities, and a decision would be taken on a wider consensus to implement a ban on social media for children below 13 years.

Iran war can have significant, lasting impact on India's economy: FinMin

Shishir Sinha

New Delhi

The Finance Ministry has expressed apprehension about a "significant and long-lasting impact" on the economy as the West Asia war escalates. A report released by the Finance Ministry on Friday noted that in the short term, India has sufficient foreign exchange reserves to provide the cushion the economy needs.

"The implications of this conflict for India are significant and may be long-lasting in ways that are not immediately understood," the *Monthly Economic Review* (MER), prepared by the Economic Affairs Department of the Finance Ministry, said.

OIL SHOCK IS BACK

It noted that the disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz and damage to key energy infrastructure in West Asia mark a pivotal escalation, echoing the 1991 Gulf War oil shocks and potentially reshaping global energy geopolitics for decades.

"This conflict has already driven Brent crude up around 9 per cent to near \$80/bbl. and LNG prices by around 50 per cent," the MER said. Nearly 40 per cent of India's crude imports and a large quantity of natural



RIPPLE EFFECT. The Strait of Hormuz disruption and damage to key energy infra in West Asia mark a pivotal escalation, reshaping global energy geopolitics for decades: Monthly Economic Report REUTERS

gas move through the choked strait.

The MER said the country has sufficient foreign exchange reserves, a low current account deficit (at 0.8 per cent of GDP in H1 FY26), and a low inflation rate, allowing it to effectively mitigate the impact of rising crude oil prices and ensure domestic energy security.

CAD, INFLATION IMPACT

"However, if the crisis persists, it could have material implications for the exchange rate and current account deficit and could stoke inflationary pressures (which otherwise have supportive supply-side dynamics)," the MER said.

Studies show that a 10 per cent increase in crude prices can knock off 10 bps in GDP

and push up the retail inflation by 30-35 bps.

CURRENCY PRESSURE

The report also said that subdued capital flows, accentuated by a flight to safety, could put pressure on the currency. "Some sectors dependent on LNG and crude, like fertilizers and petrochemicals, could be affected if the crisis is prolonged," it said.

The MER noted strong fundamentals but also cautioned against any complacency or basking in the solidity of post-Covid macroeconomic performance hitherto. "That belongs to history. The future has become that much more uncertain, with every indication that it will remain so for some time to come," it said.

With crude on the boil, Sensex and Nifty log worst weekly fall in over a year; banks lead drag

Anupama Ghosh

Mumbai

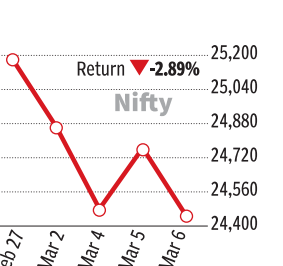
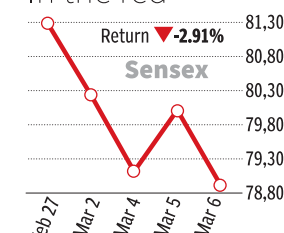
Benchmark indices recorded their steepest weekly decline in more than a year, with both the Nifty 50 and Sensex tumbling 2.9 per cent over the week ending Friday as the escalating US/Israel-Iran war roiled global markets and sent crude oil prices surging.

On Friday, the Nifty closed at 24,450.45, down 1.27 per cent, while the Sensex settled at 78,918.90, falling 1.37 per cent.

ICICI Bank fell the most in the index, losing 3.13 per cent, followed by Eternal (-2.96 per cent, Shriram Finance (-2.77 per cent, SBI (-2.54 per cent), and Axis Bank (-2.54 per cent).

Siddhartha Khemka, Head of Research at Motilal Oswal Financial Services, noted that "concerns intensified after

In the red



shipping activity through the Strait of Hormuz came to a near halt... raising fears of disruptions to global oil supplies."

FEAR SPIKE

The market fear gauge, India VIX, surged over 11 per cent on Friday, signalling a sharp rise in investor anxiety.

Vinod Nair, Head of Research at Geojit Investments, cautioned that "a sustained rise in oil prices could weigh on investor sentiment and adversely affect India's twin deficits, the

inflation trajectory, and the RBI's monetary policy stance."

BANKS DROP

PSU banks bore the brunt of the weekly sell-off, declining 6.5 per cent, while the India Tourism index lost 5.88 per cent. Friday saw the Nifty Private Bank index fall 2.3 per cent, and the Nifty Financial Services decline 2.1 per cent.

The Defence index surged 4.85 per cent for the week, rising 2.8 per cent on Friday alone, as geopolitical tensions

fuelled expectations of higher defence spending.

CAUTIOUS OUTLOOK

The market outlook remains cautious to negative. Rupak De, Senior Technical Analyst at LKP Securities, said, "Until 25,000 is crossed decisively, the trend is likely to favour a sell-on-rise strategy."

Rupee ends the week 77 paise lower

The rupee saw a see-saw movement during the week plunging to a record closing low of 92.15 per US dollar on March 4 and making a smart recovery to 91.60 the next day on heavy RBI intervention.

The Indian currency closed the week ended March 6, at 91.74 per US dollar, down 77 paise.

Read more on p3

HIMALAYAN CHANGE



JUBILANT MOOD. Supporters of the Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP) gather outside the Election Commission ahead of the announcement of results in the Nepal general elections, in Kathmandu on Friday. Rapper-turned-politician Balendra Shah's newly formed party is heading towards a sweeping victory in Nepal's first general elections since the violent Gen 2 protests last September. Popularly known as 'Balen', the 35-year-old engineer is expected to be the next Prime Minister of Nepal, reflecting the public mood to end the dominance of established political parties **p11**

US gives India 30-day waiver on Russian oil buys to curb price shocks as Iran war escalates

Amiti Sen
Rishi Ranjan Kala

New Delhi

The US has announced a 30-day easing of restrictions on India's purchase of Russian crude to avert a global price shock amid escalating tensions in West Asia.

Experts view the move as a strategic one by the Trump administration to check spiralling energy costs with an eye on the mid-term elections. However, they maintain that for New Delhi and Moscow, these energy ties must remain a matter of national sovereignty, firmly beyond American jurisdiction



US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent REUTERS

waiver to allow Indian refiners to purchase Russian oil... it only authorises transactions involving oil already stranded at sea," US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said on Thursday.

Government sources said that the order is being legally vetted for clarity on crude purchase from sanctioned entities or vessels. "We never stopped buying

Russian crude. In February, we bought 1.04 million barrels per day from Russia. The legal vetting is to get clarity on payment and other terms related to sanctioned entities or vessels," the source said.

US President Donald Trump does not want oil prices to go through the roof, which would hurt his cause badly, said trade expert Biswajit Dhar. "The US is already staring at a fall in GDP growth. If inflation hits the economy now, it would spell trouble for Trump before the mid-term elections," he said.

On February 6, Trump withdrew a 25 per cent punitive levy on Indian imports imposed in August 2025 over the purchase of Russian oil that was allegedly "fuelling" Moscow's war with Ukraine. "India has committed to stop directly or indirectly importing

Russian Federation oil, has represented that it will purchase US energy products....," the order noted.

India has been reducing its Russian oil purchases in recent months, with Russia's share down from a high of 36 per cent to about 31 per cent. "This trend could now get reversed," Dhar said.

Efforts by the US to authorise or restrict trade between the two countries raise serious questions about the principles of sovereign equality and freedom, pointed out Ajay Srivastava of GTRI (Global Trade Research Initiative).

"With supply risks rising and stocks thin, India must consider regular import of Russian oil rather than relying on narrow waivers covering cargoes already at sea," he said.

Also read p2

AI impact on jobs still limited, but hiring of fresh graduates slowing, says Anthropic research

Rohan Das

Chennai

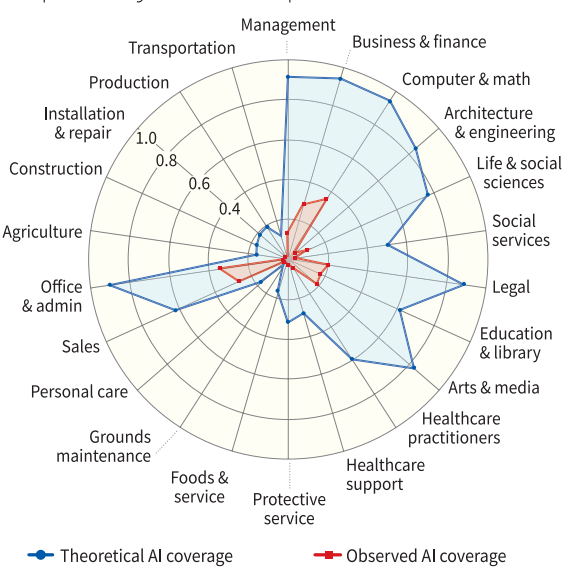
As the job market watches the advance of Artificial Intelligence with unease, new research by Anthropic, the company behind Claude, finds that while AI has the potential to reshape jobs, early signs show low actual adoption (of AI) due to legal and technical constraints.

The study also notes that AI is slowing hiring and has not yet led to job destruction.

For instance, for a role in the 'business and finance' domain, roughly 94 per cent of the job tasks can theoretically be performed by LLMs (large language models), though only 28 per cent of the tasks are being done using AI, suggesting it is still awhile for AI to impact jobs.

Computer programmers,

Occupation-wise gap between capability and adoption



Source: Anthropic Labour market impact of AI

financial analysts and customer service jobs faced the highest risk of exposure,

the study noted. On the other hand, manual jobs like mechanics, life-

guards and bartenders are expected to be insulated.

Interestingly, the report also indicates that, despite rising automation, companies are not yet laying off in vulnerable roles; instead, they have stopped hiring for high-risk jobs, thereby impacting opportunities for fresh graduates.

"Using survey data from the US, we find no impact on unemployment rates for workers in the most exposed occupations, although there's tentative evidence that hiring into those professions has slowed slightly for workers aged 22-25," Anthropic said.

WHO FACES RISK

A demographic analysis by the authors of the report also reveals that women, white people, older, and higher-paid individuals are more likely to be at risk.

QUICKLY.

‘No deal with Iran except unconditional surrender’



Washington: US President Donald Trump said on Friday there would be no deal struck with Iran except unconditional surrender, a week after launching war with Israel against Tehran. “After that, and the selection of a GREAT & ACCEPTABLE Leader(s), we, and many of our wonderful and very brave allies and partners, will work tirelessly to bring Iran back from the brink of destruction,” said Trump in a social media post, adding that they would work to boost Iran’s economy. Trump told *Reuters* on Thursday that he wants to be involved in choosing the next leader of Iran. *REUTERS*

Most of Iran’s missile launchers disabled: Israel

The Israel Defence Forces says it has demolished a majority of Iran’s ballistic-missile launchers, causing the number of missiles targeting Israel and other countries in the region to fall throughout the week. More than 60 per cent of such launchers have been “neutralised and destroyed”, said Eyal Zamir, chief of the general staff of the IDF. Zamir did not say how many had been struck, but the IDF had cited the number as 300 earlier. An IDF official said Israel is specifically targeting launchers because they are fewer in number than missiles, and destroying them can quickly limit Iranian firepower. Iran has launched ballistic missiles towards more than 10 countries in the region since Israel and the US launched a joint attack on the country last Saturday. *BLOOMBERG*

India invokes emergency powers to boost LPG output, eyes US cargoes

RISING TO THE OCCASION. The government is exploring all possible sources to get fresh supplies

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Even as India scouts for liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) supplies, including from the US and Canada, the world’s third-largest consumer has invoked emergency powers, directing domestic refiners to maximise the production of the critical cooking fuel used by over 33 crore consumers.

The government invoked the Essential Commodities Act and Petroleum Products (Maintenance of Production, Storage and Supply) Order stating that LPG — a mixture of propane and butane — is an essential domestic fuel used by households for cooking across India and that its uninterrupted supply is necessary in the public interest.

The Thursday order directs all refiners to maximise propane and butane streams



FREE FLOW. Uninterrupted supply of the critical cooking fuel, used by 33 crore consumers, is necessary in the public interest

to produce LPG and make it available to Indian Oil Corporation, Bharat Petroleum Corporation and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation.

“We are in a comfortable position on LPG. However, the government is already scouting for supplies from wherever possible, including the US, Canada and Africa.

Today’s order is also a step in the direction of maintaining adequate supplies of LPG,” said top sources.

LPG CONSUMPTION
India consumed more than 33 million tonnes of LPG in FY25, of which more than half was imported. Of this, 85-90 per cent of imports

came from West Asia, with most cargo transiting the Strait of Hormuz.

Middle East Gulf (MEG), excluding Iran, is India’s largest supplier of LPG, covering 92 per cent (around 720,000 barrels per day) imports as of 2025, as per Vortexa. Maritime consultancy Drewry pegs that nearly 40 per cent of the global LPG supply passes through the 34 km narrow passage annually.

Sources said India is already buying 2.2 million tonnes (mt), or 10 per cent of its LPG imports, from the US. The supply has already started from January 2026. Canada is another source of LPG besides Africa.

The government is exploring all possible sources to get fresh supplies, some of which are expected by March-end.

India invoking emergency powers to boost LPG production comes as the Finance Ministry’s Monthly

‘Govt will use all policy tools to help exporters tackle West Asia crisis’

Our Bureau
New Delhi



Commerce & Industry Minister Piyush Goyal

Commerce & Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said the government will use all policy tools to help Indian exporters deal with the West Asia crisis and uphold all international commitments.

“I can assure you that this government stands with our industry and will continue to ensure that all our international commitments are met...And the government will use every policy tool and the export promotion mission to support our exporters...,” said Goyal on the sidelines of IIFT Vice Chancellors’ conclave on Friday.

‘TRUSTED PARTNER’
The Minister pointed out that even during the Covid pandemic, India met all its international commitments, which earned the nation the acronym of “trusted partner”.

The Commerce Ministry is in dialogue with the Ministry of Shipping and shipping companies on the issues that concern exporters, said Goyal. With major shipping lines suspending transit through the Strait of Hormuz and Suez Canal, Indian trade is hit by rising freight and insurance costs.

“I do hope we will find a resolution to this issue also,” he said. The inter-ministerial group for supply chain resilience, formed to tackle problems arising from the emerging geopolitical situation, talks to exporters every day, said the Minister. “They take feedback, and we will not be found wanting in supporting our exporters in any way,” he said.

Industry bodies have sought urgent intervention from the government to prevent a liquidity crunch. Exporters are urging higher

RoDTEP (Remission of Duties and Taxes on Exported Products) rates, and have called on the ECGC to freeze insurance premiums despite the heightened risk.

The industry is seeking ad-hoc working-capital limits and credit extension to manage the capital locked up in stranded shipments. There are also demands for the government to waive port-related charges, such as storage and demurrage, particularly in cases where the cargo is rolled due to sudden vessel cancellations.

Exporters are also grappling with a severe shortage of containers and the frequent suspension of vessel calls to hubs in West Asia.

‘India plans ₹3 lakh cr investment to boost shipbuilding’

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said on Friday that investments worth approximately ₹3 lakh crore have been planned under the Maritime India Vision 2030 and Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047 to develop world-class shipbuilding clusters.

Reiterating self-reliance as the only solution to remain relevant, Rajnath Singh stated that the disturbance in West Asia following the US-Israel-Iran war will directly impact the supply of oil

and gas owing to disruptions in the global supply chain.

He said this in his inaugural statement at the *Sagar Sankalp - Reclaiming India’s Maritime Glory*, a defence and maritime dialogue, jointly organised by Garden Reach Shipbuilders & Engineers (GRSE) Ltd and a private media organisation in Kolkata.

POSITIVE RESULTS
The government’s efforts are yielding positive results as domestic defence production surpassed a record figure of ₹1.50 lakh crore in as FY25, with defence exports

reaching an all-time high of approximately ₹24,000 crore.

He stated that by April 2026, defence exports are poised to reach ₹29,000 crore, and the government has set a target to export defence equipment worth ₹50,000 crore by FY30.

“It is difficult to make concrete comments about the future course of events in West Asia or in our neighbourhood. The Strait of Hormuz or the entire Persian Gulf region is crucial for global energy security. When there is disturbance in the region, it directly impacts

the supply of oil and gas. Moreover, we’re witnessing supply chain disruptions in other sectors as well. These uncertainties have a direct impact on the economy and global trade. The global scenario is an abnormal situation. What is more worrying is the fact that this abnormality is becoming the new normal,” said Singh.

Describing technological dynamism as another crucial element in a fast-changing world, the Minister stated that technology is bringing about unprecedented changes across every sphere of life, and this is even more

evident in the defence sector.

SPECIAL FOCUS
He stated that in the shipbuilding sector, GRSE and other shipyards have also been given special focus to make the domestic industrial ecosystem strong and futuristic.

“The goal is to develop ships into technology hubs, not just production units. Efforts are being made to bring them up to the global standards through infrastructure modernisation, digital ship design tools, modular construction techniques and supply chain integration.”

More than 100 ceramic units in Morbi down shutters due to propane shortage

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

When propane stocks ran out at Bluezone Vittrified Pvt Ltd on Friday, one of its units fell silent, forcing the Morbi-based ceramic manufacturer to send home nearly 200 contract workers.

Bluezone is not alone. Industry estimates suggest more than 100 propane-fired ceramic units in Morbi have already shut down, as fuel supplies dry up amid global disruptions linked to escalating US-Iran tensions and shipping risks in the Strait of Hormuz, a key energy corridor.

“At least 100 units have shut down since Thursday because of the current crisis. Each unit employs around 300-400 workers,” Manoj Arvadiya, President of the Morbi Ceramic Association’s vitrified tiles division, told the *businessline*. “Those who still have gas stocks are continuing operations, others are shutting down. There is



IN DIRE STRAITS. Morbi’s ceramic cluster employs over five lakh workers, many of them migrants who depend on daily wages

no clear message from the companies selling propane in Morbi, and we have no idea what their plans are,” he added.

UNCERTAINTY LOOMS
Morbi’s ceramic cluster, among the largest tile manufacturing hubs globally, employs more than five lakh workers, many of them migrant labourers dependent on daily wages. For these workers, even temporary shutdowns quickly translate into lost income. Arvadiya, who also heads Bluezone Vitrified, said the crisis has already affected his own op-

erations. “I have three ceramic units. Two of them that use natural gas from Gujarat Gas are currently functional, but the third unit running on propane has shut down. About 50 per cent of the contract workforce attached to that unit has been asked to leave for now,” he said.

Other manufacturers are bracing for similar shutdowns as remaining propane stocks run out. “I have two units and both operate on propane gas. We have enough stocks to last us for the next two days, after which we will be forced to

In last three days, over 7,000 Indians flew back from UAE

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

Around 7,000 Indians returned to India from the UAE in the last three days, and many more are expected to travel with Etihad Airways resuming limited scheduled flights from Saturday.

Indian and foreign carriers have been operating repatriation flights from the UAE, Oman and Saudi Arabia. However, flight operations at Doha, Bahrain and Kuwait remain suspended.

Deepak Mittal, India’s Ambassador to the UAE, and Satish Sivan, Consul General in Dubai, met airline representatives on Thursday and reviewed the flight operations.

“Airlines are focused on gradually increasing the non-scheduled flights from different airports in the UAE depending on airspace safety and operational clearances by the authorities. More flights are planned in the next 48 hours from Abu Dhabi, Dubai, Ras Al Khaimah,

Sharjah and Fujairah airports,” said the Indian Embassy in the UAE in a post on X.

Etihad said it will resume a limited commercial flight schedule from Saturday between Abu Dhabi and a number of key destinations that include Ahmedabad, Bengaluru, Delhi Hyderabad and Mumbai.

The decision to operate a limited schedule has been taken in coordination with relevant authorities following extensive safety and security assessments, it said. “Etihad continues to monitor the situation closely and will only operate flights once all safety criteria are met,” the airline added.

Emirates is operating a reduced flight schedule while working to restore entire operations.

The airline anticipates a return to 100 per cent of its network within the coming days, subject to airspace availability and fulfilment of all operational requirements, it said.

Indian carriers, including Akasa Air, Air India, IndiGo and SpiceJet, are also operating scheduled and repatriation flights for affected passengers.

Since February 28, seven major airports in West Asia region have seen 19,000-plus flight cancellations.

Domestic airlines alone have cancelled over 1,500 flights to West Asian destinations, including 281 on Thursday, with the restrictions on airspace continuing. On its part, the Civil Aviation Ministry is monitoring the flight operations.

DOMESTIC FLIGHTS
Passenger movement data for Thursday show that a total of 40 inbound flights operated by Indian carriers arrived from West Asia, carrying 7,205 passengers, taking the cumulative passenger arrivals to 14,992.

For Friday, 51 flights are scheduled to be operated by Indian carriers, subject to operational feasibility and prevailing conditions.

‘Withhold TRP ratings of news channels for four weeks over war coverage’

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Ministry of Information & Broadcasting has directed the Broadcast Audience Research Council (BARC) to withhold the release of viewership data for news television channels for the next four weeks. This move is being taken in the public interest, and comes after growing concerns regarding sensational coverage of the ongoing West Asia conflict by certain news channels.

In its communication sent to BARC, the television rating points (TRPs) rating agency, the I&B Ministry said it has observed that certain news TV channels are displaying unwarranted sensationalism and speculative content related to the Israel-Iran conflict.

‘MAY CREATE PANIC’
It cautioned that such sensational content could potentially create panic among the public. The Ministry also noted that this can particularly impact those who have family and friends residing in the areas affected by the ongoing conflict.

Sources said the move is aimed at discouraging excessive dramatisation and sensationalism to garner higher TRPs, which the Ministry said, has the potential to trigger panic and anxiety among Indian citizens.

The temporary suspension of release of viewership data is also directed at discouraging competitive sensationalism.

Where will shipping lines offload Gulf cargo after ‘end of voyage’ call?

T E Raja Simhan
Aneesh Phadnis
Chennai / Mumbai

With Swiss shipping major Mediterranean Shipping Company (MSC) declaring ‘end of voyage’ for Gulf-bound shipments amid the Iran-Israel conflict, attention has now turned to where the diverted containers will actually be discharged.

In shipping parlance, an ‘end of voyage’ declaration means a vessel terminates its journey at a port other than the originally contracted destination due to unavoidable circumstances such as conflict, safety threats, or operational disruptions.

MSC has not disclosed the alternative ports where the cargo will be offloaded. However, industry sources say

Colombo in Sri Lanka and Tanjung Pelepas in Malaysia are emerging as the most likely options.

VIZHINJAM PORT
There was also speculation that the Vizhinjam International Transshipment Port in Kerala could be considered. However, sources said the port is currently operating at full capacity, and has effectively been ruled out as a diversion point.

MSC did not respond to queries sent by *businessline*.

Peter Sand, Chief Analyst at Xeneta, a Norway-based ocean and air freight rate benchmarking and market analytics platform, said traditional diversion options closer to the Arabian Gulf are increasingly becoming unsafe. “Khor Fakkan in the UAE was attractive earlier



IN HIGH SEAS. Swiss shipping major Mediterranean Shipping Company has not disclosed the alternative ports where the cargo will be offloaded

“Colombo and Tanjung Pelepas are obvious alternatives as ports on the Arabian Peninsula appear to be off limits for now. Tanjung Pelepas is attractive, though it will negatively impact port efficiency as yard density rises, and those frustrated cargoes will likely remain there for some time,” he said. The focus is shifting towards East Africa, too, he added.

A NATURAL CHOICE
J Krishnan, Partner at Chennai-based S Natesa Iyer Logistics LLP, said Colombo could be a natural choice since it lies along the main international shipping lane and offers strong Pan-Asian connectivity.

When asked whether Indian ports could be used to offload the containers, Capt K Ramakrishnan, a master

mariner, said this would be difficult under the current conditions.

“There is no spare capacity and Indian Customs will not allow such containers unless they are formally declared as transshipment cargo,” he said. Ramakrishnan added that MSC could choose to discharge containers at terminals owned or operated by the line, particularly where adequate storage space is available.

A spokesperson for German shipping line Hapag-Lloyd said the disruption is forcing carriers to identify multiple alternative locations. “Some ports are closed or cannot be reached. Different ports need to be identified to store these containers until they can be transported to their final destinations,” the spokesperson said.

businessline.

Disclaimer: Readers are requested to verify & make appropriate enquiries to satisfy themselves about the veracity of an advertisement before responding to any published in this newspaper. THG PUBLISHING PVT LTD, the Publisher & Owner of this newspaper, does not vouch for the authenticity of any advertisement or advertiser or for any of the advertiser’s products and/or services. In no event can the Owner, Publisher, Printer, Editor, Director(s), Employees of this newspaper/company be held responsible/liability in any manner whatsoever for any claims and/or damages for advertisements in this newspaper.

QUICKLY.

**RBI to conduct ₹1 lakh cr
OMO purchase auctions**



Mumbai: The RBI has decided to conduct open market operation (OMO) purchase auctions of government securities (G-Secs) in two tranches of ₹50,000 crore each, to be held on March 9 and March 13. to address the liquidity pressure the banking system could face on account of outflows due to GST payments and advance tax. These auctions aggregating ₹1 lakh crore are also intended at ensuring that G-Sec yields don't harden due to liquidity crunch in the run up to the financial year end. Currently, the banking system is having a surplus of ₹3,02,440 crore (as on March 5). However, this surplus could turn into deficit due to the aforementioned outflows. The RBI intends to buy seven G-Secs at the March 9th OMO purchase auction. **OUR BUREAU**

**Forex reserves rise \$4.88 b
to all-time high of \$729 b**

Mumbai: The country's forex reserves jumped \$4.885 billion to an all-time high of \$728.494 billion during the week ended February 27, the Reserve Bank said on Friday. In the previous reporting week, the overall reserves had dropped \$2.119 billion to \$723.608 billion. The previous all-time high for the kitty was \$725.727 billion during the week ended February 13 this year. For the week ended February 27, foreign currency assets increased \$561 million to \$573.125 billion, the data released by the central bank showed. **PTI**

**Reliance inks deal
to bring Finnish
chocolate brand
Fazer to India**

**Our Bureau
Mumbai**

Reliance Consumer Products Ltd has signed a memorandum of understanding with Finland's Fazer to produce, market, and distribute the Finnish company's premium chocolates across India, the companies announced on Friday.

The MoU was signed in Bengaluru on the sidelines of Finnish President Alexander Stubb's state visit to India. Under the agreement, RCPL will handle commercialisation and distribution of Fazer-branded chocolates manufactured using the Finnish company's recipes and quality standards.

The partnership gives Fazer access to RCPL's network of nearly three million retail outlets across India. RCPL's Director T. Krishnakumar said the deal would accelerate the company's growth in the chocolate and confectionery segment by combining Fazer's global brands with RCPL's local production and distribution capabilities.

Construction equipment segment slips in Feb on high base, slowing infra projects

**T E Raja Simhan
Chennai**

The construction equipment segment was the exception in February as all other segments of the automobile industry posted strong growth. Construction equipment retail sales stood at 6,721 units in February, marginally down 1.2 per cent from 6,804 units in February 2025, according to data from the Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (FADA). Industry analysts attribute the muted performance to a high base and a slow-down in infrastructure execution after a period of strong activity. The segment includes

I-T Dept brings cryptos, CBDCs under financial reporting net

GOVERNANCE BOOST. Move aimed at ensuring cross-border tax transparency, say experts

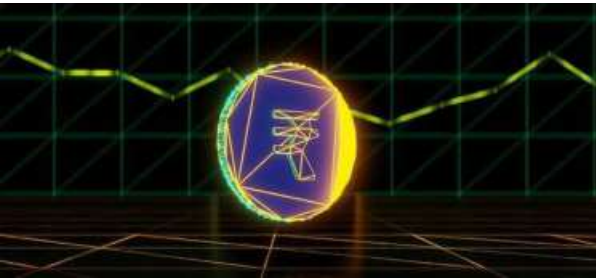
**Shishir Sinha
New Delhi**

The Income Tax Department has expanded the financial account reporting framework to include crypto-assets, central bank digital currencies (CBDCs) and certain electronic money product. This has been made effective from January 1.

Experts say that such a move aims to ensure that cross-border tax transparency keeps pace with the rapidly evolving digital financial landscape.

According to a March 5 notification by the Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT), rules have now brought 'relevant crypto-assets' within the reporting architecture. This means that crypto-asset service providers and certain financial institutions may now be required to report transactions and holdings involving such assets to tax authorities.

"The amendments come in response to global developments led by the OECD, particularly the Crypto-Asset Reporting Framework (CARF) and updates to the CRS (Common Reporting Standard)," said Sandeep Bhalla, Partner at Dhruva Advisors.



NEW FRAMEWORK. Crypto-asset service providers and certain financial institutions may now be required to report transactions and holdings involving such assets to tax authorities.

Also, definition of financial accounts and institutions to include emerging digital financial products will also include specified electronic money products (SEMPs) and central bank digital currencies (CBDCs). All these will result in the widening of scope of entities and assets covered under the Common Reporting Standard (CRS) framework.

'DEPOSITORY ACCOUNT' The rules clarified that accounts holding CBDC on behalf of customers may be treated similarly to deposit accounts in specific cases. Additionally, the definition of "depository account" has been expanded to include accounts representing electronic money products or those holding CBDC. Further, the amendments

introduce additional reporting requirements for financial institutions, including confirmation of valid self-certification from account holders, disclosure of joint account details, identification of controlling persons in entities, and classification of accounts as new or pre-existing.

Changes in Rule 114G outline the reporting requirements for financial institutions regarding the reportable account, including interest, dividends, and other income. As per the new amendment, the institutions must also report whether the account holder has provided a valid self-certification and whether the account is a joint account, including the number of joint account holders. Changes to Rule 114H clarify due diligence

procedures for identifying reportable accounts.

"Accounts that become financial accounts due to the expanded CRS definitions will be treated as new accounts from January 1, 2026, while those existing as on December 31, 2025 will be treated as pre-existing accounts," Bhalla explained.

Sumit Singhania, Partner, Deloitte India, opined that amendment represents a step forward in India's tax policy as CBDCs and specified electronic money products have now been integrated into the definition of 'depository accounts'.

AMENDED RULE

The amended rule is set to apply from January 1, 2026 and ensures that digital forms of money will be subject to same transparency and reporting standards hitherto applicable in respect of traditional physical currency.

"The introduction of the crypto-asset reporting framework requires reporting financial institutions to track gross proceeds from "relevant crypto-assets". Under these rules, interests in crypto-assets — including derivatives like futures or options — are now classified as financial assets for reporting purposes," he said.

Insurers' shift to Ind AS accounting norm to boost global compatibility, investor confidence

**G Naga Sridhar
Hyderabad**

The adoption of Ind AS by the insurers as proposed by the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) will facilitate market-based valuation (discounted basis) and will enhance the comparability of the Indian insurance industry with global players, according to experts.

ANALYSIS.

As of now, preparation and presentation of financial statements by insurers in India are governed by a comprehensive legal and regulatory framework as per the Insurance Act, 1938 (as amended), the Companies Act, 2013, and the IRDAI (Actuarial, Finance and Investment Functions of Insurers) Regulations, 2024.

Globally, IFRS 17 has replaced IFRS 4 to establish a consistent, principle-based framework for insurance contracts, with implementation effective January 1, 2023 across major jurisdictions.

In certain aspects, the existing framework differs from internationally-accepted accounting standards, particularly in areas like liability measurement, profit recognition, impairment of financial assets, and disclosure practices.

In this backdrop, the insurance regulator proposed migration to the Ind AS 117

Rupee ends the week 77 paise lower amid West Asia conflict

**Our Bureau
Mumbai**

The rupee saw a see-saw movement during the week amid the West Asia conflict, spike in crude oil prices and FPI-related outflows from the domestic equity markets, plunging to a record closing low of 92.15 per US dollar on March 4 and making a smart recovery to 91.60 the next day on heavy RBI intervention.

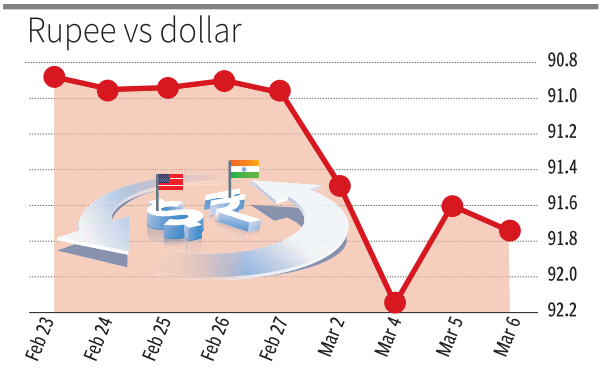
The Indian currency closed the week ended March 6, at 91.74 per US dollar, down 77 paise as compared with the previous Friday's close of 90.97. It touched an all-time intraday low of 92.30 on Wednesday.

Amit Pabari, MD, CR Forex Advisors, said that over the past week, the rupee has traded under significant pressure, largely driven by global developments rather than domestic factors.

ISING OIL PRICES

"With tensions escalating in the Middle East region, Brent crude has surged close to \$87 per barrel. For an oil-import-dependent economy like India, even a moderate rise in crude prices carries significant macroeconomic implications.

"A \$10 increase in oil prices could expand India's import bill by nearly \$15 billion and widen the current



account deficit by about 0.3 per cent of GDP. This effectively translates into stronger dollar demand and increasing pressure on the rupee," he said.

Pabari observed that against this backdrop, dollar/rupee moved back toward the 92.30 levels during the week on Wednesday, reflecting both higher oil-driven dollar demand and cautious global investor sentiment.

However, the Reserve Bank of India stepped in with intervention on Thursday, pushing the rupee back toward the 91.50 levels and offering temporary relief to the currency, which triggered a sharp one-day rebound toward the end of the week.

UNDER PRESSURE

"While this is a strategy the RBI has deployed in the past to curb excessive volatility, such support may prove difficult to sustain if strong and persistent dollar demand

continues in the market. Going forward, a sustained rise in crude oil prices, continued FII outflows, a strengthening dollar index, and any further escalation in geopolitical tensions are likely to keep the rupee under pressure.

"Technically, the 91.20-91.50 zone is emerging as strong support for dollar/rupee. On the upside, the pair remains vulnerable. A gradual move toward the 92.50-93.00 region could still be seen as global risks and oil prices remain elevated," Pabari said.

Moody's Ratings has warned that costly energy imports in the wake of the Middle East conflict would weaken the rupee, raise inflation, worsen the current account balance and complicate monetary policy as well as fiscal management if they lead to expanded subsidies to help offset the economic shock, warned.



IN PROGRESS. While most corporate entities in India have adopted Ind AS, insurers continue to prepare financial statements under the existing regulatory framework **GETTY IMAGES**

global market practice, insurance liabilities are reported on market-based valuation (discounted basis).

"Hence, adoption of IND AS 117 will enhance the comparability of the Indian insurance industry with global players, which in turn will increase the confidence of investors as well as consumers," he said.

PREPAREDNESS

IRDAI has adopted a structured and phased readiness approach since 2022, including the constitution of a Mission Mode Team and an Ind AS Expert Committee, conducting mandatory gap assessments, capacity-building initiatives, and submission of Ind AS compliant proforma financial statements.

Insurers conducted gap assessments covering data, systems, and resources, and have made significant progress in system upgrades, Contractual Service Margin (CSM) engine development and capacity building. They also submitted pro forma statements for FY24 (with most of the large insurers also for FY25), demonstrating industry preparedness for transition.

For the first year post-implementation, insurers will submit both Ind AS financial statements (statutory reporting) and IGAAP financial statements (special-purpose regulatory submission). This will facilitate assessment of the transition impact of Ind AS.

DGFT issues guidelines to roll out credit assistance measure for e-commerce exporters under EPM

**Press Trust of India
New Delhi**

MSMEs with a proven track record of at least six months of exports through postal or courier channels and having inventory in overseas warehouses for e-commerce fulfilment will be eligible for credit assistance under the ₹25,060-crore Export Promotion Mission, the DGFT said on Friday.

To support exporters using digital channels, the Commerce Ministry last month announced credit facilities with interest subvention and partial credit guarantees. It is part of the Export Promotion Mission (EPM).

The intervention seeks to

enhance access to working capital for Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) involved in international value chains through e-commerce, enabling them to manufacture goods in advance of anticipated demand and scale their participation in global markets.

CREDIT ASSISTANCE

Under this, credit guarantee cover will be available to banks for credit assistance extended by them in the form of cash credit, overdraft, or other working capital facilities to eligible beneficiary entities, in accordance with the coverage parameters.

These facilities will also be supported through interest

To support exporters using digital channels, the Commerce Ministry last month announced credit facilities with interest subvention and partial credit guarantees.

subvention with notified ceilings.

The intervention is being operationalised on a pilot basis through the Export-Import Bank of India (Exim Bank).

In a trade notice, the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) said new

MSMEs, involved in international value chains through e-commerce with prior domestic e-commerce experience shall also be eligible, subject to a minimum of one year of regular domestic e-commerce operations.

"Support shall be available to the exporters as per eligibility... Proven track record of at least six months in exporting through postal or courier; current inventory placed in overseas warehouses for e-commerce export fulfilment; and current stock placed in warehouses set up under e-commerce export hub facility," it said.

The DGFT has also issued guidelines for the launch of support for emerging export opportunities under the mission.

QUICKLY.

Second-gen Ducati DesertX V2 unveiled



The all-new Ducati DesertX V2 marks a major shift for Ducati, adopting a new 890cc V-twin producing 108.4 bhp and 9.38 kg-m. Built around a lighter monocoque chassis with the engine as a stressed member, it should have sharper dynamics on- and off-road. Long-travel KYB suspension, 21/18-inch spoked wheels, six riding modes and a 5-inch TFT headline the updates. The bike is expected to debut in India only next year, though.

Mercedes-Benz V-Class launched at ₹1.4 crore



Mercedes-Benz has offered the luxury MPV exclusively in the extra-long-wheelbase guise. The stretched configuration prioritises rear-seat comfort, delivering generous legroom and a lounge-like cabin for chauffeur-driven buyers. It features refreshed styling with AMG Line coming as standard, dual digital displays and premium trim. Power comes from a 2.0-litre diesel engine making 235 bhp and a new 2.0-litre turbo petrol unit making 228 bhp. Both are paired with a 9-speed automatic gearbox.

Mahindra XEV 9e Cineluxe Edition launched



Mahindra has introduced the XEV 9e Cineluxe Edition at ₹29.35 lakh, turning its all-electric SUV into a rolling lounge. Based on the top-spec Pack Three 79-kWh variant, the Cineluxe Edition adds two bespoke exterior finishes and a richer, theatre-inspired cabin theme with premium upholstery, enhanced ambient lighting and a feature-loaded tech suite that remain unchanged. Distinguishing it from the standard variants, there's a 'Cineluxe' badge on the C-pillar. Deliveries for this version will start March 10 onwards.

©The MotorGram



Neo world order

HYBRID THEORY. The Toyota Fortuner spawns a diesel-engined mild-hybrid version and it wears the Neo Drive moniker

Ruman Devmane

Chances are, if you're in the market for a Toyota Fortuner, you've already made up your mind about it. Buying a Fortuner isn't a matter of choosing it over other cars in its price range — it's about when you're ready for it. As such, Toyota didn't have to reinvent the wheel to boost its immensely popular SUV, so it hasn't. Instead, it's thrown in a cool little number in the form of a 48V mild-hybrid unit, which makes the Fortuner Neo Drive 4x4 AT (to give you its name in full) the range topper, outside of the Legender series. Before you think of this development as something revolutionary, though, let me tell you it isn't. Toyota claims this hybrid tech adds 46 km to its overall range which, given its 80-litre fuel tank capacity, translates to roughly a 0.5 kpl boost. Hardly noticeable, in other words. What you will notice, however, is the torque assist this system provides which has benefited urban driving performance in the form of linear low-end acceleration, something of a concern area previously. It isn't necessarily a complex setup, either, with Toyota deploying an Integrated Starter Generator that works using a belt-drive mechanism. As such, the transition between diesel and hybrid modes is seamless, although I did find the hybrid mode a bit too eager, cutting off frequently in crawling traffic. At some point in the 500 km I clocked in the Fortuner, I turned off the system (using a button placed just ahead of the arm rest) and, thereafter, ensured it stayed switched off at the beginning of every urban

drive. Behind the wheel of a Fortuner, efficiency (a negligible gain, that too) is hardly what you're thinking about. **MAGNETIC FACTORS** Among the Fortuner's many magnetic factors are its imposing road presence and its indestructible personality. I, for one, have a soft spot for body-on-ladder SUVs and, therefore, am only too happy to trade the driving sophistication of monocoques for robustness. While that's certainly a subjective call, I would urge you to sample a Fortuner on some of our less world-class roads (in Mumbai, they're hardly difficult to find). What you will thus experience is a sense of poise and nonchalance that genuinely makes light work of even the unrieliest of tarmac aberrations. Inside the cabin, you hardly hear more than a heavily muffled thud on most occasions and, most crucially, the Fortuner never feels fragile even if you take too much of a liberty with its suspension, trampling over potholes for fun. While its appearance may suggest otherwise, it's also a rather easy SUV to drive. At first, the steering does come across as heavy, but it's something you can get used to over time; for sure, it goes with the Fortuner's burly character. The electronically-adjustable driver's seat makes for a commanding driving position and all of the controls are intuitively laid out. Toyota has kept its button vendors happy with the Fortuner and you do all manner of important decision-making using hardy plastic buttons which, while lacking German premiumness, feel like they'll endure the tenure of your ownership. And Fortuners, typically, are driven for lakhs of kilometres on average, so



A LASTING EFFECT. The Fortuner's cabin lacks the panache of its contemporaries, but it feels unmistakably built-to-last YASH GAWDE

that's an important aspect. Driving one in the city is a relaxing experience, with the 2.8-litre four-cylinder engine being handsomely responsive, thanks to the 201 bhp and 50.9 kg-m it generates, even if it isn't trying to emulate a car-like crispness that some of its peers deliver. A heavy foot on the accelerator pedal does generate a noticeable amount of engine noise, however, which is something Toyota should address if it wants to inconvenience its monocoque rivals. Road noise is fairly muted, thankfully. **IMPRESSIVE DRIVE** On the highway, the Fortuner impresses even more, with its composure really lending it an enviable long-haul ability. It really is the kind of SUV you can mindlessly set off on a road trip with, always assured of a good ride quality and a stress-free cabin experience. If you're an enthusiastic driver, the Fortuner

will underwhelm you in corners thanks to its pronounced body roll. If you think that's a fair trade-off for what is a tough SUV that can do day-long drives effortlessly, you'll find no reason to complain, of course. While I spent barely any time in its backseat, I can say with certainty that the Fortuner is undoubtedly a front-row car. The middle row of seating (it's a bench) is elaborately spacious and comfortable but not opulent by any measure. Space is decent in the third row, too, but perhaps best reserved for a pair of energetic kids. And yes, even with the third row left upright, there is a decent amount of luggage space; a pair of check-in trolleys fit there comfortably, as I found out on an airport run. Among other things you will appreciate is the outward visibility, and the addition of a 360-degree camera sure helps with parking in tight spots, even if the on-screen display for the same appears dated; it's the same for the rest of the infotainment package, too, in fact. Is the Neo Drive variant, priced at ₹42.3 lakh, the one you must automatically opt for, then? Not necessarily. For one, if 4x4 isn't a must for you, the 4x2 diesel-auto version is priced at a considerably lower ₹36.96 lakh. In fact, the diesel-auto (4x2) variant of even the Legender marginally undercuts this variant, with its ₹42.1 lakh price tag (all prices ex-showroom, pan-India). I suppose if you're the sort of person who simplifies buying decisions by simply asking for the 'top model', this is a pointless consideration. In any case, do you remember that thing about being in the market for a Fortuner? You've already made up your mind about it, haven't you?

©The MotorGram

Light work

CAUTIOUSLY CLEVER. The Honda Shine 100 DX takes a measured approach to the entry-level commuter class, aiming to dominate



ESSENTIAL SERVICES. The Shine 100 DX keeps its features list crisp. Digital instrumentation is comprehensive, featuring a distance-to-empty readout and easy readability YASH GAWDE

Ruman Devmane

This is the toughest class of motorcycle to crack. Fuel-efficiency dominates the conversation — as it has, for decades now — equalled by an intimidatingly high degree of price sensitivity. Honda's newest addition to this class (an eternal Hero MotoCorp Splendor monopoly) is well aware of this reality. And it's really done its homework. Honda appears to have arrived at the Shine 100 DX having taken a deep breath and reassessed the

100cc segment. The cat-and-mouse spreadsheet-clout-chasing approach that typically plagues this class (and also some higher segments) has been avoided, and that should explain why the Shine 100 DX is, despite being the newest in this league, the least powerful, at 7.2 bhp. Given how critical cracking this class of motorcycles is to Honda and others, this output figure must have been arrived at through a data-driven approach. It seems plausible that commuters find little utility in the marginally extra power its rivals offer.

EASY RIDER

Instead, Honda has chosen to make the Shine the lightest motorcycle in its class, with a kerb weight of 103 kg. The Hero Splendor, for instance, is 9 kg heavier and the Bajaj Platina, 14 kg heavier! You feel this in an instant, dismounting it from its centre stand and certainly on the move as well. It's a delightfully easy motorcycle to shift through tight traffic on, aided by its 17-inch alloy wheels wrapped with MRF NyloGrip Zapper-C tubeless tyres. In the 180 km I rode the

Shine, it felt tireless, nimble and just very easygoing. Perhaps, 18-inch wheels would add a stronger sense of stability and composure, although that's not to say the Shine is lacking in this regard. The 98.9cc single-cylinder engine is, of course, the heart of the matter and develops its peak torque of 0.8 kg-m earlier than any of its rivals — at 5000 rpm, as compared to the Platina's 5500 rpm and Splendor's 6000 rpm. This sets the tone for the kind of rideability you can expect from the Shine, indeed allowing you to crawl comfortably at even 30 kph

in fourth gear, while being able to pull away towards the top end of its performance without downshifting. Beyond 70 kph, though, the Shine begins to feel strained (acceptable, in context of the class) with a buzz incrementally emerging through its footpegs. **URBAN BLISS** What feels enjoyable is really low-speed urban riding, where the engine's refinement and especially the gearshift quality shines. It sure doesn't offer the buttery smoothness of a 125, but on its own, it's a really pleasant motor-

cycle to run errands on. As long as you ride it in an 'efficiency' frame of mind, you'll struggle to find fault with it. What I didn't enjoy as much were the brakes. The front drum is prone to fading under aggressive usage, requiring the rear brake to chip in. I also wished for a firmer seat (not what the masses want, apparently); an hour of riding later, I did begin to experience tailbone discomfort. Fortunately, the Shine on the whole is an ergonomically generous motorcycle, so at no point did I feel cramped

or too large for it, even if I am! Is the Shine 100 DX a no-brainer, given that its ₹71,743 (ex-showroom, Mumbai) price tag undercuts the Splendor by a little over ₹3,000? That, mind you, is roughly two months' worth of fuel expenses, if you commute 40 km a day and extract 60 kpl (easy; can go higher, too) from it. The answer is 'yes' if a light, effortless and robust motorcycle is your idea of an ideal commuter. And if you have a thing against monopolies.

©The MotorGram

QUICKLY.

US stocks fall on W. Asian
turmoil, weak jobs report



Wall Street's main indexes fell on Friday, with the financials-heavy Dow at a more than three-month low, as the conflict raging in the Middle East threatened to fuel inflation and data showed the economy unexpectedly shed jobs in February. The data pointing to a weakening jobs market came amid a strike by healthcare workers and harsh winter weather. The unemployment rate increased to 4.4 per cent. Following the data, traders raised expectations that the Federal Reserve will lower interest rates by 25 basis points in June, odds of which now stand at about even, up from about 35 per cent earlier in the day, according to LSEG-complied data. REUTERS

Sedemac Mechatronics
IPO subscribed 2.68 times

New Delhi: The initial public offering of Sedemac Mechatronics, a powertrain controls and auto parts manufacturer, received 2.68 times subscription on the last day of bidding on Friday. The ₹1,087-crore IPO got bids for 1,51,11,151 shares against 56,32,899 shares on offer, as per data available with the NSE. The category for qualified institutional buyers attracted 8.46 times subscription. The portion for non-institutional investors received 77 per cent subscription and retail individual investors category got subscribed 20 per cent. Sedemac Mechatronics has garnered ₹32.26 crore from anchor investors. **■**

BROKER'S CALL.

Geojit Retail Equity Research

LT FOODS (BUY)
Target: ₹518
CMP: ₹393.00
LT Foods (LTF) is a global consumer specialty company with an explicit focus on basmati rice, organic foods and ready-to-eat/cook (RTE/RTC) products. It has a presence in over 80 countries with significant regional exposure in the US, Europe, West Asia, etc.
Revenue grew 24 per cent year on year (normalised growth at 8 per cent excluding US tariff and Golden Star revenue) for Q3FY26, led by broad-based strength across geographies despite the US tariff headwind. Gross margin improved 70 bps to 34.2 per cent, while EBITDA margin grew only 20 bps to 11.2 per cent.
LTF targets ₹1,000 crore each from the recently set-up manufacturing facility in the UK and the expanded distribution in Saudi Arabia in the next five years. EBITDA margin is expected to improve as the company scales up its value-added segments. The RTC/RTE segment is projected to grow at about 35 per cent and is likely to achieve break-even at around ₹400 crore in revenue by FY27.
The strong focus on regional and product diversification is expected to support healthy earnings growth and re-rating. Currently, LTF has only less than 9 per cent exposure to West Asia. We value the stock at 17x on FY28 EPS (three-year average 17x) to arrive at a target price of ₹518 and recommend BUY due to healthy volume outlook.

InCred Equities

HYUNDAI MOTOR INDIA (REDUCE)
Target: ₹1,904
CMP: ₹2,089.35
Hyundai Motor India Q3FY26 EBITDA rose 8 per cent year on year but fell 17 per cent quarter on quarter to ₹2,020 crore, a sharp miss vs our estimate (13 per cent)/Bloomberg consensus estimate (-17 per cent). The management expects strong wholesales, supported by GST-led demand tailwinds and optimal dealer inventory level below four weeks in January 2026 (vs five weeks typically) as against two-three weeks as of end-December 2025. Exports continue to maintain their strong momentum and are likely to exceed earlier guidance of 7-8 per cent growth. A price hike was implemented on January 1, 2026, to pass on the cost increase to customers. The continued underperformance in domestic market volume recovery is an area of concern, leading to volume cut of 1-2 per cent for FY26F-28F. The weakness in EBITDA margin from new plant costs led to our 1-3 per cent EBITDA cut for FY26F-28F. Despite refreshed new products launched recently and commissioning of Pune plant, the company's participation is domestic industry volume recovery post GST rate cut is an area of concern. With EPS cuts, we roll forward and reduce our target P/E to 22x, from 24x earlier, leading to a lower target price of ₹1,904 vs ₹2,023 earlier. The current rich valuation led us to retain our REDUCE rating on the stock.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: **blmarketwatch@gmail.com**

Gold ETF inflows plunge 77% in Feb as price fall shakes investor sentiment

BULLION SURGE. Prices had been rising on geopolitical tensions and trade uncertainty, peaking after higher US tariffs

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

The inflows into gold exchange-traded funds plunged 77 per cent last month to \$565 million, compared with a record high of \$2.5 billion logged in January, as the sudden sharp fall in gold prices rattled investor sentiment. Gold prices have been rallying over the last few months on the back of geopolitical developments and peaked after the US imposed high trade tariffs, rattling the world.

YEARLY INFLOWS
Gold ETF inflows so far this year have surged to \$3.06 billion, pushing assets under management close to \$20

billion, according to World Gold Council data. This compares with inflows of \$4.69 billion last year, \$1.29 billion in 2024, \$310 million in 2023 and just \$33 million in 2022. Redemptions from some of the larger funds earlier in the month were likely driven by profit-taking as the gold price pulled back, but these were gradually offset as the month progressed, underscoring sustained interest in gold ETFs, the Council said.

SEBI RULE BOOST
The growing interest was further supported by the SEBI's recent overhaul of the mutual fund scheme-categorisation framework, which now allows equity mutual fund schemes to invest the residual portion of



WGC DATA. Despite the February slowdown, gold ETF inflows this year have reached \$3.06 billion, pushing total assets under management close to \$20 billion

their assets in gold and silver ETFs, it said. Shweta Rajani, Mutual Fund Head, Anand Rathii Wealth, said the gold ETF inflows hit a record high in January at ₹24,040 crore, which was higher than ₹24,028 recorded by all

equity MF schemes put together in a single month. The investments were on the back of a 24 per cent surge in gold prices to an all-time high of ₹1.75 lakh per 10 grams in January, she said. However, the mood

SAT gives partial relief to Kotak AMC, sets aside fee disgorgement in Essel FMP case

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Securities Appellate Tribunal (SAT) has partly allowed an appeal filed by Kotak Mahindra Asset Management Company (Kotak AMC) in a case related to investments by its fixed maturity plans (FMPs) in Essel Group-linked entities, while upholding penalties imposed by the market regulator. In an order dated March 6, the tribunal set aside a direction issued by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) requiring Kotak AMC to disgorge a

portion of the investment management and advisory fees collected from investors in six FMP schemes. However, it upheld findings of regulatory lapses and dismissed a separate appeal challenging monetary penalties imposed on the asset manager, its trustee company and certain officials. The case relates to investments made by Kotak Mutual Fund's six closed-ended FMPs in zero-coupon non-convertible debentures issued by Essel Group-linked firms Konti Infrapower & Multiventures and Edison Utility Works. The investments were backed by pledged shares of Zee Enter-

tainment Enterprises, part of the Essel Group. The tribunal held that the fund house had failed to exercise adequate due diligence while making the investments, noting that the decisions were largely based on the reputation of the Essel Group and the pledged shares rather than the financial strength of the issuer entities. SAT also observed that Kotak AMC delayed informing investors about adverse developments after the share price of Zee Entertainment fell sharply in January 2019, reducing the value of the pledged collateral.

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Canara Robeco Mutual Fund believes the impact of the US-led war between Israel and Iran will be limited, as an amicable solution will be reached sooner rather than later. Shridatta Bhandwadar, Head of Equities, Canara Robeco Mutual Fund, said money is the main ingredient that prolongs war. In the battle between Russia and Ukraine, the latter managed to strike back, supported by the US and Europe. In the case of the Israel-Iran war, the constraint of money is clearly visible from the number of missiles and



Shridatta Bhandwadar, Head of Equities, Canara Robeco MF

drones being fired by Iran coming down from about 100 to 10-12 a day now, he said.

LIMITED INDIA IMPACT
While the benchmark indices have fallen since the war broke out, the direct impact on the Indian economy

Bank Nifty falls nearly 2% on crude oil worries, FII outflows

Madhu Balaji
Bengaluru

Banking and financial stocks ended sharply lower on Friday, dragging the Bank Nifty down about 2 per cent as broad-based selling gripped the sector. All constituents of the index settled in the red, as concerns about rising crude oil prices, geopolitical tensions, and foreign fund outflows also dampened sentiment. All these would disrupt or delay the current monetary easing cycle, creating uncertainty for banks. "Additionally, the RBI's proposed regulations on loan-linked insurance sales have added to the pressure," Vinod Nair, Head of research, Geojit Investments, said. Market experts believe that this move could reduce banks' fee-based income and weigh on overall profitability.

BANKING SELL-OFF
ICICI Bank emerged as the

biggest laggard within the sector. Punjab National Bank, State Bank of India, Axis Bank, HDFC Bank, Bank of Baroda and IndusInd Bank also ended lower, posting losses of around 2-3 per cent each. According to Nitant Darekar, Research Analyst at Bonanza, the fall largely reflects investors' locking in gains after the sector's strong performance over the past year, even as global developments heightened nervousness. "However, we believe that the immediate reaction can be the US-Israel-Iran conflict that has resulted into increasing crude oil prices with India importing nearly 80-85 per cent. This is important because it can increase our import costs, and with the further weakening of the rupee, inflation could rise, which could push the RBI to increase rates and thus affect banks' profits due to slower loan growth," he said.

'Israel-Iran war impact on India may be limited'

will be limited except for the spike in oil prices and subsequent impact on the rupee, he added. Indian economy is in a better shape with corporate earnings bouncing back and valuation of top-200 companies close to their historic levels, said Bhandwadar at the launch of the fund house's Banking and Financial Services Fund.

NEW FUND STRATEGY
The portfolio of the new fund will be split into steady compounders with established leaders, strong balance sheets and low risk, accounting for 70 per cent of the investment, while growth accelerators and disruptors will make up the rest to deliver the much-needed

alpha, he said. The Canara Robeco Banking and Financial Services fund will provide a steady risk-adjusted return that will be beneficial even in a volatile market, he added. The impact of Artificial Intelligence on the IT sector can be gauged only after reviewing the numbers over a few quarters, he said. Investors' expectations from mid- and small-cap stocks have come down to reasonable levels after the recent crash, he added. Currently, the fund house is underweight on FMCG, oil and gas and metals. Overweight on auto ancillary, pharma, defence and industrials, especially companies focused on the power sector.

From labs to listings: IIT start-ups ride the IPO wave

RINGSIDE
VIEW.

KS BADRI NARAYANAN

Nothing demonstrates the proverb "Nothing succeeds like success" more vividly than the accomplishments of educational institutions. This is particularly evident in premier institutes such as the Indian Institutes of Technology. The recent initial public offerings (IPOs) from new wave of companies highlight how these nationally important institutions have expanded their influence beyond education and into the world of entrepreneurship. It was Sir Ardeshtir Dalal from the Viceroy's Executive Council who triggered a thought process to establish Indian Institutes of Technology. India's first Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru established Indian Institutes of Technology to provide trained technical personnel of international class to the nation who would act as leaders in technology.

IIT EXPANSION
According to Council of In-

dian Institute of Technology, the institutions were to be designed with the necessary dynamism, flexibility of organisation and capacity to adapt in the light of expanding knowledge and changes in the socio-economic requirements of modern society. IIT-Kharagpur was the first to be launched in 1950-51 and within a decade four more were established — IIT Bombay, IIT Madras, IIT Kanpur and IIT Delhi. Currently, there are 23 such high-profile institutions, serving in various engineering and science fields.

TECH INCUBATION
The recent IPO market has highlighted IITs and similar institutions in a dynamic new role, driven by the strength of their incubation cells — emerging as leading hubs for deep-tech start-ups. These incubation centres bring together the institute's strengths in innovation and entrepreneurship, supported by advanced research and strong industry collaborations. They empower students, faculty, staff, alumni, and external entrepreneurs to build disruptive deep-tech ventures that reshape industries and create meaningful societal impact. These ef-



IPO MONETISATION. IITM Incubation Cell and IITMS Rural Technology and Business Incubator sold 31,050 shares and 4,191 shares in Ather Energy IPO last year

forts are beginning to pay off well. The IPO of Sedemac Mechatronics Ltd that closed today was established by IIT Bombay. Founded in a lab at the IIT Bombay, in 2007, Shashikanth Suryanarayanan, Amit Arun Dixit, Manish Sharma and Anyankumar Avinash Joshi have built on their technical expertise to place Sedemac amongst the top players in the Integrated Starter Generator Engine Control Unit (ISG ECU) market for 2W and 3W (combined) and the largest supplier of genset controllers in India. In 2008, the promoters (alumnus of IIT) gave 7 per cent of their

company's equity to IIT Bombay's Society for Innovation and Entrepreneurship (SINE). Of which, SINE sold 2.04 lakh shares amounting to around ₹28 crore in the IPO. Sedemac's ₹1,087.45 crore was entirely an offer-for-sale and came out with a price band of ₹1,287 and ₹1,352 per share, valuing the company around ₹6,000 crore. Similarly, IITM Incubation Cell and IITMS Rural Technology and Business Incubator sold 31,050 shares and 4,191 shares in Ather Energy IPO last year. They had held a combined 15.58 lakh shares in Ather Energy, which was founded in 2013.

MFs enable unit freeze to promote digital security

Our Bureau
Mumbai

In a bid to promote digital security of units of investors in Mutual Funds, capital market regulator SEBI has introduced voluntary debit freeze facility across demat and non-demat folios. The move will ensure no units will be debited from such folios till they are unlocked. The facility will come into effect from April 30. In the first phase, the facility to lock the folio will be provided to investors by the RTAs through MF Central platform. It will be enabled only for KYC-compliant investors having valid Email ID and Mobile number, said SEBI.

Jio IPO faces delay as govt yet to formalise new listing rules

Bloomberg

The government's delays in formalising changes to listing rules are threatening to force Mukesh Ambani, to miss the targeted timeline for an initial public offering of shares in Jio Platforms Ltd, the digital arm of his flagship company Reliance Industries. Reliance is waiting for the government to formalise the changes backed by the regulator to appoint bankers formally and file a draft IPO prospectus, according to people familiar with the matter. The company is now aiming to file the draft prospectus before April, depending on the government notification, they said. Jio, which owns India's



largest wireless operator, is one of the crown jewels of Ambani's empire and its IPO — the first listing of a major Reliance unit in almost 20 years — could be the country's biggest ever. Investment bankers have proposed a valuation of as much as \$170 billion for the company. Ambani said in August that Reliance was aiming to list Jio in the first half of 2026, a plan he had first signalled 2019 — back then with a five-year timeline.

Nifty 50 Movers					▼ 315.45 pts.
	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Reliance Ind	1404.80	22.81	19.44	8.51	
Bharat Elec	468.45	6.64	57.43	1.51	
Sun Pharma	1799.40	3.46	39.42	1.71	
WIPAC	380.50	2.65	14.86	1.02	
ONGC	278.95	2.22	7.80	0.97	
Infosys	1308.40	2.00	18.94	4.11	
Hindalco	958.90	1.25	13.40	1.24	
HCL Tech	1356.70	0.60	22.35	1.28	
Bajaj Auto	9816.00	0.28	30.85	0.98	
NestleIndia	1252.40	0.24	74.04	0.20	
Wipro	195.40	-0.18	15.37	0.50	
Tech Mahindra	1331.70	-0.22	28.42	0.76	
PowerGrid Corp	299.15	-0.30	17.92	1.22	
SBI Life	1941.60	-0.33	79.37	0.78	
TataConsumerProduct	1116.70	-0.34	75.10	0.65	
Grasim Ind	2718.40	-0.48	19.53	0.93	
Cipla	1231.20	-0.64	23.54	0.67	
Asian Paints	2279.50	-0.82	55.92	0.92	
Apollo Hosp	7724.50	-1.14	59.53	0.71	
Dr Reddys Lab	1303.80	-1.30	19.70	0.71	
Tata Motors PV	350.75	-2.02	47.70	0.66	
Max Healthcare	1042.00	-2.64	71.42	0.70	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	239.35	-2.74	94.76	0.20	
Titan	4244.60	-2.77	79.07	1.57	
Adani Enter	2039.90	-2.82	16.66	0.48	
JSW Steel	1233.70	-2.97	38.85	1.04	
M&M	3332.50	-3.04	24.52	2.67	
Trent Ltd.	3722.80	-3.31	81.70	0.74	
Adani Ports	1477.50	-3.53	27.24	0.98	
HDFC Life	668.55	-3.71	76.19	0.64	
ITC	309.70	-3.81	18.74	2.68	
Tata Steel	198.46	-3.83	27.16	1.47	
Eicher Motors	7620.50	-4.06	39.02	0.94	
Coal India	440.45	-4.46	9.12	0.90	
ITCS	2557.60	-4.75	19.29	2.34	
Bajaj Finserv	1868.90	-5.31	24.76	0.64	
IntiglobeAvi	4404.10	-5.39	53.03	0.89	
Hind Unilever	2225.70	-5.70	52.01	1.77	
Bajaj Finance	950.20	-7.11	32.27	2.26	
Maruti Suzuki	14159.00	-7.37	29.81	1.67	
UltraTech Cement	11987.00	-7.83	46.10	1.27	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	375.50	-6.80	20.72	1.27	
Eternal Ltd.	232.57	-11.93	971.59	1.50	
Kotak Bank	399.80	-12.10	21.15	2.64	
Axis Bank	1315.80	-20.94	15.49	3.38	
Bharti Airtel	1870.80	-22.13	28.79	4.66	
L&T	3949.80	-22.90	28.63	4.16	
State Bank	1148.00	-24.12	12.19	4.26	
ICICI Bank	1313.40	-69.24	16.59	1.42	
HDFC Bank	857.05	-69.46	17.03	11.76	

Nifty Next 50 Movers					▼ 245.55 pts.
	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Hindustaneronautics	4023.70	75.09	30.25	3.39	
United Spirits	1389.80	56.71	58.77	1.83	
Vedanta	721.00	49.62	17.02	5.44	
Solar Industries	1553.00	35.16	89.18	1.54	
Cg Power & Ind Sol	715.45	29.56	101.55	2.18	
Mazagon Dock	2471.90	27.22	41.43	0.84	
Abb India	6062.00	20.93	76.17	1.41	
Avenueesuper	3875.80	17.85	88.06	2.54	
Siemens Energy India	2920.60	15.05	88.05	1.15	
Siemens	3265.00	14.71	73.42	1.28	
Jsw Energy	488.20	14.01	32.77	1.16	
Varun Beverages	447.65	7.80	49.44	2.72	
Britannia Ind	5983.00	7.08	59.64	3.14	
Adani Energy Solutions	992.50	4.79	50.02	1.53	
icici Lombard Gic	1880.30	3.70	33.44	2.02	
Indian Railway Finance Corp	99.47	3.32	18.55	0.79	
Bosch	3335.00	2.73	35.66	1.29	
Zyduslisciences	913.05	-1.20	18.28	1.02	
Bajaj Housing Finance	84.14	-1.38	28.29	0.35	
Havells	1349.20	-2.50	57.07	1.51	
Ltimindtree	4292.00	-4.01	26.94	1.77	
Jindal Steel	1180.40	-4.04	59.73	1.96	
Tata Power	375.50	-6.80	20.72	2.80	
Lic	822.30	-7.09	10.18	0.81	
Gall (India)	155.71	-8.25	11.90	1.87	
Rural Elec	339.15	-10.12	5.18	1.88	
Torrent Pharma	4317.80	-11.17	64.32	2.01	
Pilditind	1433.80	-11.27	63.06	1.98	
Hindus Zinc	586.85	-11.45	21.01	1.13	
Shree Cement	2453.00	-13.04	49.57	1.42	
Adani Power	138.99	-13.26	23.72	2.44	
Bajaj Holdings	10560.00	-13.38	13.11	2.03	
Divis Lab	6329.00	-13.63	67.78	3.58	
Dif	577.55	-14.63	32.28	1.65	
Indian Hotels Co.	623.85	-15.42	41.03	2.44	
Hyundai Motor India	2094.20	-16.71	73.42	1.28	
Godrej Consumer	1116.60	-19.07	62.72	2.00	
Macrotech Developers	889.25	-22.79	26.55	1.11	
AdaniGreenenergy	858.40	-24.05	76.18	1.17	
Tvs Motor Cmp	3784.00	-24.23	58.87	3.95	
Ambuja Cements	466.75	-24.24	23.44	1.27	
Power Finance	407.85	-25.34	89.18	1.54	
Canara Bank	145.97	-25.59	7.19	2.19	
Punjab Natl Bank	119.31	-29.90	7.67	1.83	
Indian Oilcorp	168.68	-32.06	6.46	2.80	
Bank Of Baroda	295.35	-36.18	7.77	2.44	
Info Edge I	980.10	-41.03	37.72	1.69	
Bpcl	352.75	-44.20	6.22	3.04	
Saukandhoshinternatml	122.77	-47.57	35.24	2.42	
Cholamandalamin&fin	1625.30	-54.18	28.31	3.06	

Pts: Impact on index movement

QUICKLY.

PM to inaugurate projects worth ₹33,500 cr in Delhi

New Delhi: PM Narendra Modi will launch and lay the foundation stones of multiple development projects, including inaugurating two new corridors of the Delhi Metro, in the national capital on Sunday. The total cost of the projects is around ₹33,500 crore. Modi will also lay the foundation stone for three new corridors under Phase V-A of the Delhi Metro. **PTI**

Parandur airport gets ‘Special Project’ status

Chennai: Tamil Nadu Governor has declared the Parandur New Greenfield Airport Project as a ‘Special Project’ under the Tamil Nadu Land Consolidation (for Special Projects) Act, 2023. A Gazette notification was published in this regard on March 2. Under the Act, a Special Project refers to any project that requires at least 100 hectares of land and enables faster acquisition and approvals. **OUR BUREAU**

Karnataka Budget FY27 pegs spending at ₹4.49 lakh cr

TIGHTROPE WALK. The State govt attempts to strike a balance between its welfare commitments and large-scale infrastructure investments

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah on Friday presented the State Budget, with an outlay of ₹4.49 lakh crore for 2026–27, about 10 per cent higher than the previous year. The State government has attempted to strike a balance between the welfare commitments and large-scale infrastructure investments.

Opening his three-and-a-half-hour budget speech, Siddaramaiah said the budget was dedicated to farmers, women, youth, backward classes and minorities, reiterating the government’s focus on social welfare. He was presenting the State budget for the 17th time placing him among the most prolific State finance heads in India. Vajubhai Vala, has presented 18 budgets in Gujarat and later served as Karnataka’s Governor; and K

M Mani of Kerala and former Karnataka Chief Minister Ramakrishna Hegde have each presented 13 State budgets.

For 2026–27, total revenue receipts are estimated at ₹3.15 lakh crore, including ₹2.20 lakh crore from the State’s own tax revenue, ₹16,000 crore from non-tax revenue, and ₹79,050 crore as transfers from the Union government. Including gross borrowings of ₹1.32 lakh crore and non-debt capital receipts of ₹190 crore, total receipts are estimated at ₹4.47 lakh crore.

The State has projected a total expenditure of ₹4.48 lakh crore, comprising ₹3.38 lakh crore in revenue expenditure, ₹74,682 crore in capital expenditure, and ₹35,316 crore towards loan repayments. The budget estimates a revenue deficit of ₹22,957 crore and a fiscal deficit of ₹97,449 crore, equivalent to 2.95 per cent of the State’s Gross State Domestic



DEDICATED TO FARMERS, WOMEN...Chief Minister Siddaramaiah, who also holds the finance portfolio, arrives to present the State Budget at the Vidhana Soudha in Bengaluru **PTI**

Product (GSDP). Total liabilities by the end of the fiscal year are projected to reach ₹8.24 lakh crore, or 24.94 per cent of GSDP.

A substantial portion of spending continues to be directed toward the government’s flagship guarantee schemes. The Gruha Lak-

shmi scheme has been allocated ₹34,243.39 crore, while Gruha Jyothi has received ₹10,578 crore. The An-nabhagya food security programme is set to receive ₹6,200 crore, and Shakti, which provides free bus travel for women, has been allocated ₹5,300 crore. The

IN A NUTSHELL

- Total expenditure for 2026–27 - **₹4.49 lakh crore**
- Gross borrowings - **₹1.32 lakh crore**
- Total Revenue receipts - **₹3.15 lakh crore**
- Total liabilities - **₹8.24 lakh crore**

Yuvaniidhi unemployment assistance scheme has been allocated ₹718.18 crore.

INFRA PROJECTS Alongside welfare spending, the government has outlined a series of major infrastructure projects, particularly for Bengaluru. A 40-km underground tunnel road network, estimated to cost ₹40,000 crore, has been approved to address the city’s worsening traffic congestion. In north Bengaluru, the Hebbal-

Maharashtra Budget proposes ₹7.69 lakh crore outlay

Radheshyam Jadhav
Pune

Maharashtra Chief Minister and Finance Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Friday presented the State Budget for 2026–27, outlining an ambitious roadmap for agricultural relief, infrastructure expansion and long-term economic growth.

The Budget with a total outlay of ₹7.69 lakh crore, revenue receipts estimated at ₹6.16 lakh crore and revenue expenditure at ₹6.56 lakh crore, leaves a revenue deficit of ₹40,552 crore.

A key highlight of the budget is a farm loan waiver of up to ₹2 lakh under the Punnyashlok Ahilyadevi

Holkar Farmer Loan Waiver Scheme for farmers whose crop loans remained unpaid as of September 30, 2025. Farmers who repaid loans on time will receive an incentive of ₹50,000, a measure aimed at balancing relief with encouragement for financial discipline.

FOCUS ON AGRI

The government also announced plans to bring 5 lakh hectares under natural farming, expand the digital agriculture ecosystem by integrating platforms such as Agristack and MahaDBT, and promote artificial intelligence-based agricultural services through initiatives like MahaVistar AI and agriculture data exchanges.



FOR THE PEOPLE. Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis, MoS for Finance Ashish Jaiswal, Deputy CM Sunetra Pawar and other MLAs arrive at the Assembly on Friday **PTI**

In irrigation and water management, the State has proposed several major projects, including river-linking schemes and flood mitigation works in Kolhapur and Sangli with World Bank support of ₹2,240 crore. The

government aims to ensure 55 litres per capita per day water supply in rural areas and 135 litres in urban areas by 2047.

Key infrastructure development initiatives include Mumbai Metro expansion,

Pune Metro Phase-II, new airports including Navi Mumbai and Gadchiroli, and development of the Vadavan Port, which is expected to generate more than 12 lakh jobs. The Budget also emphasises welfare and human development initiatives. Ladki Bahin scheme has been continued, while the Lakh-pati Didi programme aims to enable 25 lakh more women to earn annual incomes of ₹1 lakh through self-help group activities.

The government will also establish a Maharashtra Institute of Public Health in Nagpur and implement a ₹4,500 crore programme for early detection of cancer, diabetes and heart disease in rural areas.

Stalin lays down Vision 2030 for TN

Our Bureau
Chennai

With the Assembly polls around the corner, a confident Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK)-led Tamil Nadu government presented a five-year vision for the State.

Chief Minister MK Stalin on Friday asserted the government will come back to power, while outlining the Vision Tamil Nadu 2030 framework, which highlighted the goals for his government across 14 focus sectors/departments including health, education, industrial development, urban planning and others.

In line with its earlier goal of becoming a \$1 trillion economy by 2030, he said the government will focus on a ‘Make in Tamil Nadu’ initiative, to bring industrial activity to every district. “Tamil Nadu will emerge as India’s economic powerhouse. To achieve this, our target is to attract ₹18 lakh crore in in-



TN Chief Minister M K Stalin

vestments, create 50 lakh jobs for youth, and increase Tamil Nadu’s exports to \$120 billion,” CM said.

The Industries Department will also work toward a five-fold growth in electronics exports by 2030, and we will double IT exports from ₹2.5 lakh crore to ₹6 lakh crore and create 2 lakh new IT jobs, he said. “The textile industry will be modernised, and the livelihoods of 35,000 workers in Tiruppur and Karur will be secured,” he added.

2030 GOALS

Interestingly, the 2030 goals highlighted by the CM also

includes a plan to develop a Large Language Model (LLM) specifically for the Tamil language. Housing for all, expanded medical insurance coverage, mental health counselling centres in every district, and integration of AI in education, are among other goals set.

The Chief Minister also said that to ensure that all the goals in Vision Tamil Nadu 2030 become a reality, the State will prepare district-wise action plans. “The Dravidian development model will continue,” he added.

Finance Minister Thangam Thennarasu said of the 550 initiatives/schemes put forward by the DMK when it came to power in 2021, they have implemented around 206 of them and 170 are in progress, making it a 75 per cent conversion. 32 schemes are under consideration by the State, 33 are with the Centre for their action, 44 have not been taken up, and 20 were not feasible, he added.

Siddaramiah announces new scheme to boost farmers’ income

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Karnataka has announced a ₹100 crore scheme ‘Chief Minister’s Krishi Vistara’ to boost farmers income by strengthening post harvest activities and market linkages.

Presenting the State Budget for 2026-27, Chief Minister Siddaramiah said the CM’s Krishi Vistara scheme with an outlay of ₹100 crore over next three years will create stable and additional sources of income for rural farmers by comprehensively strengthening post-harvest activities such as processing, value addition, value chain development, recycling of agricultural waste and market linkages.

Further, the ‘Millet Hub’ being established to promote millet and organic products in the State will be developed



into a self sustaining institution. It will function as a single window system to provide technical assistance, processing facilities, quality certification and market linkages to farmers, rural youth and agri-entrepreneurs, he said.

Siddaramiah also announced the ‘Vasudhamruta’ programme to promote eco-friendly and sustainable practices over the next three years.

Further, the State will pro-

mote the Alternate Wetting and Drying (AWD) method of irrigation to increase the water use efficiency in paddy cultivation as well as strengthening the State’s efforts in climate change adaptation.

The State is also setting up ‘Raitha Malls’ through the Mysore Sales International Ltd on a pilot basis in Kolar district to provide high quality agri inputs including seeds, pesticides, fertiliser and agricultural implements at affordable rates to farmers.

HORTICULTURE

To attract investment and to promote value-addition in horticulture sector, high-value farms, post-harvest technologies and horticulture-based industries will be established in farms and nurseries of horticulture department under Public-Private Partnership, Siddaramiah said.

Thozhi hostels show safety is key to women employment: Report



HOUSING FACTOR. A Thozhi a working women’s hostel at Tambaram (File photo)

Our Bureau
Chennai

The availability of affordable, secure, and organised accommodation plays a critical role in enabling educated women to migrate to cities, enter employment, and sustain their careers, according to the latest white paper from the Centre for Finance and Economic Research (CFER) at the Great Lakes Institute of Management.

The study analysed Tamil Nadu’s *Thozhi* hostels, run by the Tamil Nadu Working Women’s Hostels Corporations Ltd, a State government initiative. Its findings reveal that such State-backed hostels for women function as ‘labour-market infrastructure’.

These hostels, which have been operating at approximately 87 per cent occupancy across Tamil Nadu, house women from at least 12 States and Union Territories and enable women to remain in jobs during uncertain early-career phases, build financial independence, defer marriage, and exercise greater control over life decisions, the study said.

The report added that formal security systems such as biometric access, CCTV, women-only premises, combined with government affiliation, generate family confidence. Meanwhile, food

quality, infrastructure maintenance, and the absence of job information or financial guidance were flagged as friction points that reduce the hostel’s effectiveness as a transitional support.

WHITE PAPER

The study was released on the occasion of International Women’s Day 2026 in association with the Madras Management Association, at an event here on Friday. The event also saw a release of a white paper on paid work participation and daily work intensity among young adults aged 20–29 years.

Speaking at the event, Gangapriya Chakraverti, India Site Head and MD, Ford Motor Company, said, “India cannot speak of a demographic dividend if half its young women are unable to participate in paid work. Industry has a responsibility to look beyond hiring and examine the structural constraints: housing, mobility, safety, that determine whether women can even enter the workforce.”

Vidya Mahambare, Union Bank Chair Professor of Economics and Chairperson, CFER, Great Lakes Institute of Management, said the way forward would be for other States to adopt the *Thozhi* hostels model and recognise affordable accommodation for women as part of its economic infrastructure.

Mobility and logistics activity remains muted in Feb: Shriram Mobility Bulletin

Our Bureau
Chennai

India’s mobility and logistics sector witnessed relatively stable trucking activity during February.

Data indicates that truck rentals across key trunk routes remained range-bound month-on-month, even as several routes continued to record year-on-year (y-o-y) growth. The Delhi–Mumbai–Delhi route recorded y-o-y growth of 8 per cent, while the Delhi–Kolkata–Delhi and Mumbai–Chennai–Mumbai routes each posted 6 per cent growth. The Bengaluru–Mumbai–Bengaluru route recorded 5 per cent growth, while the Guwahati–Mumbai–Guwahati route increased by 4 per cent y-o-y,



Shriram Mobility Bulletin Passenger vehicles and two-wheelers saw a 28 per cent and 8 per cent dip in February which could be a result of customers waiting for special offers expected during upcoming Gudi Padwa/ Ugadi festivals in March, said the bulletin.

STRONG GROWTH

On a y-o-y basis, multiple commercial vehicle segments continued to record

strong growth. Goods carrier sales increased by 32 per cent, while three-wheeler goods vehicles also recorded growth of 32 per cent. Commercial tractor sales grew by 33 per cent, while maxi cab sales rose by 35 per cent y-o-y, highlighting sustained demand from logistics and utility transport segments.

“Logistics activity in India remained subdued in February, with truck rentals across key trunk routes largely rangebound. With fiscal year-end goods movement and a pickup in agricultural freight expected, rentals are likely to stay firm in March, though possible rise in fuel prices remain a key risk,” said Sudarshan Holla, Joint Managing Director & Chief Operating Officer, Commercial Vehicles, Shriram Finance.

Karnataka to strengthen fisheries infrastructure

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

The Karnataka government has announced measures to strengthen fisheries infrastructure in the State, including the construction of new fish markets and to establish a centre of excellence in Mangaluru.

Presenting the 2026-27 Budget, Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah said the government will set up fish markets in Uttara Kannada, Dakshina Kannada, Udupi and Bagalkot districtsto address the need for well-equipped fish markets.

MATSYA DARSHINIS

In its efforts to promote fish consumption and make clean and quality fish products available to the public, the government will

set up ‘Matsya Darshinis’ in Belagavi, Davangere, Hubballi and Chikkamagaluru districts of the State.

He said a Centre of Excellence will be established at Fisheries College in Mangaluru. To encourage fishing activities, the government has doubled value of fisheries kits provided free of cost to fishermen to ₹20,000.

TO ADVERTISE PLEASE CONTACT

Chennai : 044 - 28576300
Coimbatore : 0422 - 2212572
Madurai : 0452 - 2528497
Trichy : 0431 - 2302801
Puducherry : 0413 - 2224111

thehindu**businessline.**

NOTICE TO LOCKER HOLDERS

DEFAULTERS IN PAYMENT OF LOCKER RENT

This notice is to customers who have taken lockers on rent at various branches of **HDFC Bank Ltd** and not paid the rent for more than 3 years.

The Bank has send several notices to the customers from time to time calling upon to make payment of locker rentals, but no response received. This is the final notice is given to all the persons mentioned below to pay the arrears of locker rentals within a period of 60 days, failing which the bank will proceed to break open the locker at the locker hirer's cost, risk and responsibility. The bank reserves the right to proceed legally for recovery of outstanding rent, cost and other charges if any.

Sr No.	Branch Name	Customer Name	Locker No.	Locker Series	Locker Type	Overdue since date
1	VANAGARAM	SATISH SARAVANAKUMAR S	116	A02	SMALL	2020

For more details contact

The Branch Manager, **HDFC Bank Ltd(Vanagaram Branch).**,
G1 Block C Radhe Shyam Apartments, 60ft Road, Adayalampattu ,
Vanagaram, Chennai - 600095.
Contact No - 87545 96728



Noida airport gets aerodrome, security clearances to start ops

REGULATORY GO-AHEAD. DGCA green light comes after final nod from Bureau of Civil Aviation Security

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi



FACILITY READINESS. All major infrastructure required for operations is now complete, says NIA

After missing several completion deadlines, the Noida International Airport (NIA) has now secured both aerodrome and security clearances, moving the greenfield airport at Jewar a step closer to start commercial domestic operations.

On Friday, the airport received its aerodrome licence from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), certifying that the facility meets regulatory requirements related to operational procedures, safety systems, infrastructure, navigation aids and emergency response.

PASSENGER SERVICE

The development comes a day after the Bureau of Civil Aviation Security (BCAS) granted final security clearance for domestic passenger operations as well as domestic and international cargo services.

businessline had reported on Friday (March 5) that the

airport had secured the crucial security clearance from BCAS, marking a major milestone in its operational readiness.

In technical parlance, the licence confirms that the airport's airside infrastructure, flight operations procedures and safety systems comply with DGCA's Civil Aviation Requirements.

Notably, the next regulatory step will involve approval of the Aerodrome Security Programme by BCAS.

Once this is cleared, authorities will coordinate with airline partners to plan

the formal inauguration and commencement of commercial operations.

A major operational milestone had already been achieved in December 2024 when IndiGo conducted a validation flight using an Airbus A320 to test the airport's approach procedures, navigation aids and air traffic control systems.

KEY MILESTONE

"Receiving the aerodrome licence is a key milestone in our journey. It reflects the strong collaboration with our partners and the rigor-

ous work undertaken to ensure readiness for commercial operations," Christoph Schnellmann, Chief Executive Officer of Noida International Airport, said.

MOBILITY SERVICES

As per NIA, all major infrastructure required for operations is now complete, and essential concessions have been awarded across mobility services, ground handling, in-flight catering, aviation fuel, cargo, retail, food and beverage, and the airport hotel.

Besides, communications and navigation systems have been commissioned by the Airports Authority of India.

Last month, Schnellmann told *businessline* that the operational readiness process would involve finalising airline networks and route plans, as well as completing slot filing and approval procedures with the DGCA and other stakeholders.

Once slots are approved, airlines typically begin commercial preparations such as opening ticket sales and initiating customer outreach

ahead of launch.

In terms of the city side, the airport is preparing surface connectivity to support passengers from the first day of operations.

Schnellmann had pointed out that the mobility options will include intercity and long-haul bus services, airport taxis and cab aggregators, supported by intelligent traffic management systems to regulate traffic flow.

Looking ahead, he said long-term connectivity could be strengthened through a proposed Regional Rapid Transit System link from Ghaziabad and a planned high-speed rail corridor between Delhi and Varanasi, with a stop at the airport.

STRATEGIC DEAL

On airline partnerships, IndiGo will be the launch carrier at NIA. The airport has also entered into a strategic partnership with Akasa Air, which plans to operate both domestic and international services, while Air India Express is set to begin flights as well.

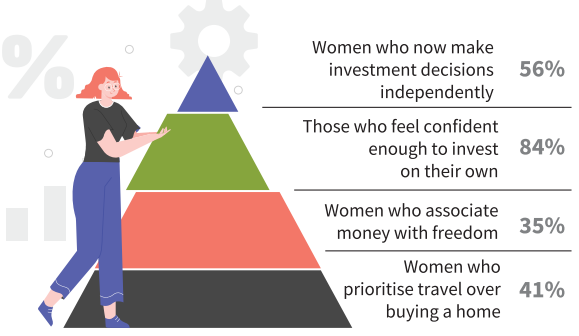
VISUALLY.

Compiled by **Yashaswani Chauhan** | Graphic: **Visveswaran V**

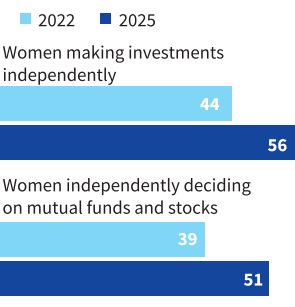
More women taking charge of investments

Urban India is seeing a quiet financial shift. More women are stepping up as decision-makers in household investments. According to the DSP Winvestor Pulse survey conducted by YouGov, women are increasingly investing independently and engaging more actively with financial information. While the gender gap still exists in some areas, the data show a clear rise in financial confidence and participation among women

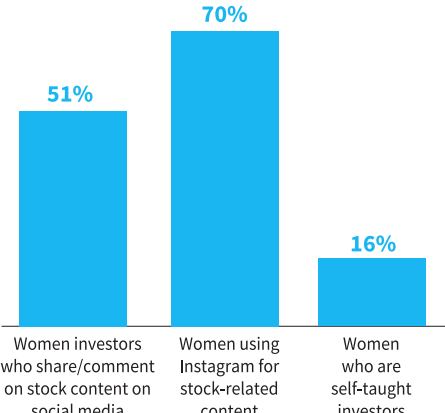
Key factoids: How investment landscape is changing for Indian women



Women are increasingly taking charge of investment decisions (in %)

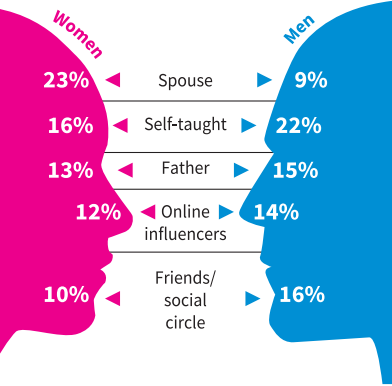


Women investors are increasingly engaging with financial content online



Nearly a quarter of women say their spouse introduced them to investing

Entry points into investing across genders



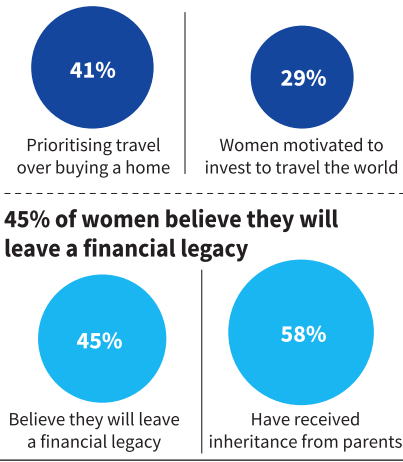
Professional financial advice gaining traction among women investors (in %)

Indicator	2022	2025
Consulting professional sources for investment decisions	57	64
Consulting bank relationship manager	19	27
Consulting family/friends for investment decisions	78	76



Source: DSP Winvestor Pulse

Travel and life experiences are shaping women's financial goals



Flipkart sacks 500 in annual performance review cycle

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

E-commerce major Flipkart has asked about 400-500 employees to leave following its latest annual performance review cycle, according to multiple people aware of the development.

The layoffs account for roughly 3-4 per cent of the e-commerce company's workforce, which is higher than the 1-2 per cent of employees

it typically lets go through performance-linked exits each year.

ACROSS SECTIONS

The exercise has affected employees across several functions, including operations, engineering and marketing, the people cited above said.

Flipkart currently employs around 18,000-20,000 people.

In a statement, the Walmart-owned company said

the move was part of its routine performance management process.

"Flipkart conducts regular performance reviews aligned with clearly defined expectations. As part of this process, a small percentage of employees may transition from the organisation. We are supporting affected employees with transition support," the company said.

The latest round of exits comes as Flipkart sharpens

its focus on operational efficiency ahead of a potential public listing. The company has been preparing for an initial public offering that could take place in the next year or so.

SHIFTING BASE

As part of these preparations, Flipkart has already begun shifting its corporate structure to India. In December, the company received approval from the National

Company Law Tribunal to relocate its holding company from Singapore to India — a move widely seen as a precursor to its listing plans.

This is not the first time Flipkart has undertaken workforce rationalisation in recent years.

In 2023, the company reportedly let go of around 1,000-1,200 employees. In 2024 as well, it reduced headcount by an estimated 5-7 per cent.

Amazon sees double-digit growth in the sale of ACs

Mithun Dasgupta
Kolkata

E-commerce giant Amazon, which has started witnessing pickup in air conditioners and refrigerators sales, is expecting a strong double-digit year-on-year sales growth in terms of value for summer categories in the consumer electronics space.

The company feels the reduction in goods and services tax (GST) rates and its latest initiatives on AI to offer consumers different propositions at the time of purchase would boost sales for the summer categories.

With effect from September 22, 2025, GST on key consumer electronics like air conditioners, TVs and refrigerators has been reduced from 28 per cent to 18 per cent.

"The summer season is setting in. The weather was

not that hot till about two weeks back, but now we are seeing large pickup in sale for the summer categories," said Zeba Khan, Director, Consumer Electronics, Amazon India.

"The GST revision has not only helped new customers, but also helped people upgrade and buy more premium products. We are seeing very strong numbers as the temperatures have been rising. The good thing is a lot of demand is coming from tier two, tier three cities, not just Metro," Khan told *businessline*.

SIX-FOLD JUMP

Amazon said cities like Indore were currently witnessing nearly a six-fold year-on-year jump in demand for five-star tonne ACs. For one-and-half tonne five-star ACs, the demand increase was four-fold compared to last year.

SpiceJet's Gulf focus leaves it most exposed to West Asia turmoil

Amit Vijay Mohile
Anesh Phadnis
Mumbai

Budget carrier SpiceJet's overseas network, though relatively small, is the most geographically concentrated among Indian airlines, with all 22 of its daily international flights in March operating to Gulf destinations, leaving the carrier proportionally the most exposed to disruptions in West Asian airspace.

The schedule data from Cirium, which is a leading provider of comprehensive aviation data, tracking over 99 per cent of global commercial flights, show the SpiceJet is the only major Indian carrier whose entire international network is concentrated in a single geographic corridor, with Dubai, Fujairah and Sharjah being the key destinations after the airline suspended operations to Bangkok,

Phuket and Kathmandu.

The airline has about 154 scheduled flights a day, meaning international services account for roughly 14 per cent of its network; its entire international operation is currently dependent on the Gulf corridor.

WIDE NETWORKS

Other Indian carriers maintain more diversified international networks. Cirium data show IndiGo has 267 international flights daily, of which 135 are to Gulf destinations, while Air India has 158 international flights, with 36 to the Gulf.

Air India Express, whose business model is heavily focused on the region, has 125 international flights daily with about 112 serving Gulf routes, while Akasa Air schedules 21 international flights, 17 of which are to Gulf destinations.

Aviation analysts monitoring the sector suggest that such concentration, while ef-



SHOCK EXPOSURE. Aviation analysts monitoring the sector suggest that such concentration, while efficient in stable markets, leaves little room for flexibility during geopolitical crisis

ficient in stable markets, leaves little room for flexibility during geopolitical shocks.

"Diversification acts as a natural hedge in aviation," noted an industry analyst. "While concentration can drive yields in normal times, it quickly turns into a strategic bottleneck when tested by geopolitics."

AIRSPACE DISRUPTIONS

SpiceJet, however, played down concerns that the situation poses a significant operational or financial risk. "International operations

factors and have been key to the airline's revival strategy.

Dubai's aviation and daily operations are currently facing significant disruptions due to the escalating West Asia crisis. As of March 6, 2026, the situation is fluid with a gradual, phased resumption of flights following widespread regional airspace closures. Flight Operations Status has now moved to partial resumption, with operations at Dubai International and Al Maktoum International airports partially resumed after a near-total shutdown earlier this week.

According to the airline, demand rebounded quickly after the reopening of airspace in the region.

STRONG DEMAND

"Following the reopening of the airspace, demand has been very strong, and we have been operating special flights to the UAE. Dubai and the wider West Asia continue to remain an important and

robust market for Indian carriers, and we remain confident about the long-term prospects," the spokesperson added.

The airline also rejected suggestions that recent airspace restrictions had hurt revenues. "There has been no revenue loss due to the brief airspace closure," the spokesperson said.

SpiceJet also pointed to structural limits on expansion on the India-UAE corridor, noting that bilateral air service agreements are already fully utilised.

"The bilateral seat entitlements between India and the UAE are fully utilised". On broadbasing its international operation, the airline spokesperson said, "SpiceJet holds traffic rights to multiple international destinations. Capacity can be re-deployed across both international and domestic routes, if required, in line with operational and commercial considerations."

Restaurants, multiplexes are gearing up for blockbuster Sunday

They expect a surge in customers for T20 World Cup final between India and New Zealand

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Restaurants, brands and multiplexes are padded up for the final match of ICC Men's T20 World Cup, which will see India clash with New Zealand.

Restaurant players expect to see sharp spike in footfalls and food delivery orders on Sunday while multiplexes are gearing up for strong occupancies for the final match.

The tournament has been garnering high viewership ratings and any last-minute ad inventory will be sold at a hefty premium, senior industry executives pointed out.

Rahul Singh, Founder, The Beer Cafe said, "India's fantastic win in the semi-final has set up what is going to be a blockbuster final this Sunday. We are expecting one of the biggest screening days across



VIEWER APPEAL. The tournament, which witnessed robust advertiser interest, has also garnered strong viewership ratings

our outlets, with footfalls and revenues likely to see a 2x jump compared to a regular Sunday.

Sagar Daryani, President, NRAI and CEO and Co-Founder, Wow! Momo Foods said food delivery orders are expected to see a sharp spike during match hours, with average order value likely to rise by 20-25

per cent. Restaurants are already witnessing rise in advance bookings.

Divya Aggarwal, Chief Growth Officer, Impresario Entertainment & Hospitality Pvt Ltd said, "With live screenings across all SOCIAL outlets, we're already seeing early momentum build, with pre-bookings currently tracking about 10-15 per cent

higher than a typical Sunday, and we expect that demand to continue rising as we get closer to match day."

ROBUST INTEREST

The tournament, which witnessed robust advertiser interest, has also garnered strong viewership ratings.

Vinay Hegde, CEO Investments, Madison Communications said, "Sponsorship economics were already strong before the final. Even before the knockout stage, advertiser demand for the tournament was robust. India's performance simply unlocked the upside on any unsold inventory. A 30-50 per cent spike in rates can be expected. The overall ratings have been better than usual especially with even non-India matches doing well."

Navin Khemka, President-Client Solutions, WPP Me-

dia, South Asia, stated, "Given India's stellar performance, the World Cup matches have witnessed an unprecedented surge in viewership. The tournament has been seeing a consistent flow of advertisers. Brands that have been associated with the tournament right from the start will be seeing the benefits."

Meanwhile, multiplexes, which have been screening World Cup matches on the big screen, too expect to garner strong occupancies on Sunday. "We've seen a good 35 per cent occupancy across our theatres nationwide in selected screens. The interest continues to build as we screen the World Cup Final on Sunday, giving fans a chance to share this moment together," said Gautam Dutta, CEO - Growth & Revenue, PVRINOX.

Odisha-based start-up IG Defence developing long-range strike drone

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Inspired by Iranian Shahed-class unmanned systems that have invited global attention for their strategic ability to carry explosive payloads across long distances at relatively low cost, Odisha-based start-up IG Defence is putting together an indigenous version of that under 'Project KAL'.

According to the company, Project KAL is aimed at developing a Made-in-India long-range strike unmanned platform having projected range of up to 1,000 kilometres and an endurance of approximately three to five hours.

STRIKE PLATFORM

The system is being envisioned as a deep-penetration strike platform capable of

operating far beyond the frontline much like Shahed-136 Iran is using with much effective outcomes against US ground, aerial and maritime assets and Gulf states.

This has forced US, as per international news reports, to reach out to Ukraine to buy interceptors to fend off Iranian drones.

TARGET AREAS

IG Defence officials, however, are unwilling to share much details as they said that their project is at "advanced stage" and will take a few months for realisation.

The company though said in a statement that the proposed drone is expected to travel deep into contested environments while remaining airborne long enough to observe target areas, adapt its flight profile if required,

and execute strikes at the most effective moment.

Commenting on the development, Maj Gen R C Padhi (Retd), Senior Vice-President, IG Defence, said, "With Project KAL, our objective is for home-grown capability in this emerging category of long-range strike drones and contribute to India's growing defence innovation ecosystem. Developing such technologies will strengthen strategic autonomy while advancing the vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat in advanced defence manufacturing."

LOGISTICS HUBS

It is also designed to carry a high-explosive payload to engage high-value targets such as strategic infrastructure, logistics hubs, radar installations, and other critical military assets.

[illegible]

R

[illegible]

RAIN (2)	133.66	132.93	133.73	138.95	131.60	182.63	135.75	99.85	-	132.90	Stylam Inc.	222.99	222.20	223.05	223.60	221.04	38.89	243.900	146.94	10.00	WHEELS India	88.40	88.05	88.80	89.50	87.70	19.39	99.259	568.78	18.87	18.77	LICAMC-LICMID100	58.26	57.64	4.04	27.50	46.03	
	121.50	121.90	121.00	121.00	116.40	171.20	174.75	109.00	-	-	Styrenex Per	187.10	186.74	187.20	187.35	185.55	24.19	343.98	143.15	10.00	WINDRUPCO	107.50	107.00	107.00	108.00	103.00	16.59	147.10	756.47	37	89.55	LICAMC-LICMID200	58.26	57.64	4.04	27.50	46.03	
Rainbow Chk	5.62	5.61	5.62	5.61	5.62	5.61	5.62	5.61	-	-	Subsidiary	187.10	186.74	187.20	187.35	185.55	24.19	343.98	143.15	10.00	WINDRUPCO	107.50	107.00	107.00	108.00	103.00	16.59	147.10	756.47	37	89.55	LICAMC-LICMID200	58.26	57.64	4.04	27.50	46.03	
Raj Engine	59.78	61.36	59.78	62.34	59.58	502.93	145.58	57.77	-	-	SUBROS_2	73.05	71.35	73.05	73.40	71.50	4.74	121.44	50.15	28	717.90	Wipro Ltd.	195.68	195.40	195.60	198.00	190.00	90.222	29.80	19.20	17	19.50	LICAMC-LICMID200	58.26	57.64	4.04	27.50	46.03
Rajratan Gso	405.39	395.80	405.10	406.20	394.80	73.40	54.00	260.00	-	-	SUDARSH_CK	820.70	817.45	820.00	825.75	811.25	49.81	162.60	81.80	29	814.10	Wardlaw's	130.52	129.90	130.15	134.60	129.84	130.00	101.70	115.70	105	129.85	LICAMC-LICMID200	58.26	57.64	4.04	27.50	46.03
Rajratan Gso	557.25	557.25	557.25	557.25	557.25	557.25	557.25	557.25	-	-	SUBROS_2	73.05	71.35	73.05	73.40	71.50	4.74	121.44	50.15	28	717.90	Wipro Ltd.	195.68	195.40	195.60	198.00	190.00	90.222	29.80	19.20	17	19.50	LICAMC-LICMID200	58.26	57.64	4.04	27.50	46.03
Ram Ratna Wv	346.85	352.85	347.00	355.45	343.15	111.75	78.95	26.80	-	-	Sula Vine	166.45	166.12	167.10	172.00	165.00	68.31	335.92	162.57	-	-	Wondraco	490.25	494.65	490.05	498.00	487.05	76.34	716.60	464.65	38	495.95	LICAMC-LICMID200	58.26	57.64	4.04	27.50	46.03
Rama Neev	34.32	35.88	35.34	38.48	34.98	227.48	45.19	26.89	-	36.04	Sumat Inc.	28.61	30.64	28.00	30.89	28.00	37.00	40.55	10.53	-	-	X-Z	62.60	62.68	62.30	63.50	62.12	60.97	104.75	61.38	15	62.96	LICAMC-LICMID200	58.26	57.64	4.04	27.50	46.03
Rama Phos	118.43	115.73	118.41	121.02	114.10	83.64	27.19	80.85	-	-	Sumitro Chem	397.30	395.25	397.30	401.00	393.00	129.14	665.00	38.60	-	-	X-Z	62.60	62.68	62.30	63.50	62.12	60.97	104.75	61.38	15	62.96	LICAMC-LICMID200	58.26	57.64	4.04	27.50	46.03
Rama Phos	61.14	61.14	61.14	61.14	61.14	61.14	61.14	61.14	-	6.36	Sumitro Chem	397.30	395.25	397.30	401.00	393.00	129.14	665.00	38.60	-	-	X-Z	62.60	62.68	62.30	63.50	62.12	60.97	104.75	61.38	15	62.96	LICAMC-LICMID200	58.26	57.64	4.04	27.50	46.03
Ramco System	419.65	405.15	418.82	426.70	414.20	95.12	88.61	288.20	69	406.45	Sun Pharma.	178.45	179.40	178.45	180.65	177.18																						

Exchange Traded Funds

[illegible]SFL
SG[illegible]

*: Closing price is the average of trade price(s) for the last half an hour; 52-Week High/Low figures

pertain to BSE.

Shares of face value other than ₹10 is indicated in brackets immediately following the name of the company.

Qty (No of shares traded) is denoted in thousands.

The PE(price-earnings multiple) of each stock is based on the latest declared earnings.

[illegible]